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PURPLE STYLE LABS LIMITED
(TO BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF BSE AND NSE)

Registered and Corporate Office: CTS No. 1081, Plot no. 110, TPS Village, Service Road, Western Express Highway, Vile Parle East, Mumbai - 400 057, Maharashtra, India

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INITIAL PUBLIC OFFERING OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH ("EQUITY SHARES") OF PURPLE ISSUE LABS LIMITED (OUR "COMPANY" OR THE "ISSUER") FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹[●] PER EQUITY SHARE (INCLUDING A SHARE PREMIUM OF ₹[●] PER EQUITY SHARE) ("ISSUE PRICE") AGGREGATING UP TO ₹6,800.00 MILLION (THE "ISSUE") COMPRISING A FRESH ISSUE OF UP TO [●] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹10 EACH AGGREGATING UP TO ₹6,800.00 MILLION (THE "FRESH ISSUE"). THE ISSUE SHALL CONSTITUTE [●]% OF THE POST-ISSUE PAID-UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF OUR COMPANY.

The details of the Fresh Issue and the post Issue market capitalization of the Company, each at the Floor Price and the Cap Price, are given below:

⁽¹⁾The UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5.00 p.m. on the Bid/Issue Closing Date.

THE ISSUE IS BEING MADE THROUGH THE BOOK BUILDING PROCESS IN ACCORDANCE WITH REGULATION 6(2) OF THE SEBI ICDR REGULATIONS.
THE EQUITY SHARES OF OUR COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF THE STOCK EXCHANGES. NSE SHALL BE THE DESIGNATED STOCK EXCHANGE.
QIB PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 75% OF THE ISSUE | NON-INSTITUTIONAL PORTION: NOT MORE THAN 15% OF THE ISSUE | RETAIL PORTION: NOT MORE THAN 10% OF THE ISSUE

IN MAKING AN INVESTMENT DECISION, POTENTIAL INVESTORS MUST ONLY RELY ON THE INFORMATION INCLUDED IN THE RED HERRING PROSPECTUS AND THE TERMS OF THE ISSUE, INCLUDING THE RISKS INVOLVED AND NOT RELY ON ANY OTHER EXTERNAL SOURCES OF INFORMATION ABOUT THE ISSUE AVAILABLE IN ANY MANNER. IN RELATION TO PRICE BAND, POTENTIAL INVESTORS SHOULD ONLY REFER TO THE PRE-ISSUE AND PRICE BAND ADVERTISEMENT FOR THE ISSUE AND SHOULD NOT RELY ON ANY MEDIA ARTICLES / REPORTS IN RELATION TO THE VALUATION OF THE COMPANY AS THESE ARE NOT ENDORSED, PUBLISHED OR CONFIRMED EITHER BY THE COMPANY OR THE BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS TO THE ISSUE ("BRLMs").

IN ACCORDANCE WITH THE RECOMMENDATION OF THE COMMITTEE OF INDEPENDENT DIRECTORS OF OUR COMPANY, PURSUANT TO ITS RESOLUTION DATED AUGUST 25, 2026, THE ABOVE PROVIDED PRICE BAND IS JUSTIFIED BASED ON QUANTITATIVE FACTORS/ KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATORS ("KPI") DISCLOSED IN THE 'BASIS FOR ISSUE PRICE' SECTION BEGINNING ON PAGE 117 OF THE RHP *VS-A-VIS* THE WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION ("WACA") OF PRIMARY AND SECONDARY TRANSACTION(S), AS APPLICABLE, DISCLOSED IN 'BASIS FOR ISSUE PRICE' SECTION BEGINNING ON PAGE 117 OF THE RHP AND PROVIDED BELOW IN THIS ADVERTISEMENT.

For details, refer to section titled “Risk Factors” beginning on page 16 of the RHP

We incurred net losses and negative operating cash flows in Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024. There can be no assurance that we will not incur losses or negative operating cash flows in the future as we expand our operations. The following table sets forth certain financial information for the Fiscals indicated:

High indebtedness, weak debt servicing metrics, and reliance on external financing may constrain our liquidity and growth. Failure to generate sufficient cash flows, secure financing, or comply with debt covenants could adversely affect our operations, financial condition, and expansion plans.

*Debt service coverage ratio is calculated as earnings before exceptional item, depreciation and interest divided by total borrowings.

We derive a significant portion of our Total PPUS GMV from our Experience Centers in India, which contributed 74.72%, 66.41%, and 56.20% of Total PPUS GMV in Fiscal 2026, 2025, and 2024, respectively*. Additionally, within India, our Experience Centers in Mumbai and Delhi accounted for 28.42% and 22.94%, respectively, of Total PPUS GMV in Fiscal 2026.

**This does not include PPUS GMV derived from UK and US as PPUS GMV attributable to the UK and US are omni-channel.*

Our dependence on mobile platforms, app store policies, device compatibility, and technology changes could adversely impact accessibility, growth, and engagement. Failure to maintain mobile ecosystem partnerships, platform compatibility, site performance, or evolving consumer preferences may reduce engagement and sales.

Our growth depends on attracting new customers, retaining repeat buyers, maintaining brand

reputation, and delivering a superior shopping experience. Failure to sustain customer acquisition, engagement, spending levels, or marketing effectiveness could adversely affect revenue, profitability, and growth prospects.

A significant share of our Total PPUS GMV is concentrated among top designer brands. Our top 10 Designer Brands contributed 30.24%, 26.54% and 23.44% of our Total PPUS GMV in Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024, respectively. Failure to retain existing brands, onboard new brands, manage supplier concentration, or address product quality and pricing challenges could adversely affect customer demand, revenue, and growth.

The sale price or maximum retail price at which the products are sold through our channels are not within our control. Limited control over product pricing and non-exclusive brand agreements may reduce competitiveness, customer conversion, and traffic. Higher prices versus other channels or reduced brand participation could adversely affect sales, profitability, and responsiveness to changing consumer preferences.

Our right to use certain intellectual property acquired under the IP Agreements has been challenged. We have received a notice seeking termination of the License Agreement alleging contractual breaches, which we have disputed. While our Company has responded to the Notice, denying such allegations, any further claims, disputes, or legal proceedings relating to these intellectual property rights could adversely affect our business, operations, and reputation.

Our business is dependent on the sale of womenswear for a significant portion of our revenues, contributing 77.70%, 75.66%, and 77.88% of our Total PPUS GMV in Fiscal 2026, 2025, and 2024, respectively. Negative trends in womenswear demand, economic conditions, trade policies, or tariffs may reduce business volumes.

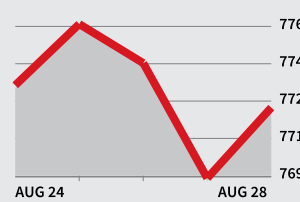
Company proposes to utilize the Net Proceeds towards (i) investment in our wholly owned Subsidiary, PSL Retail for expenditure towards lease liabilities of Experience Centers, and back-end offices in India; (ii) funding towards sales and marketing expenses to be incurred by our Company; and (iii) general corporate purposes. The usage of our Net Proceeds towards these Objects will not result in the creation of any identifiable assets.

**The rent expenses relate solely to the Experience Centers of our Company, in India and abroad, and do not include any rent expenses in relation to short-term pop-up stores, warehouses or offices.*

Continued on next page..

J CH-CHE

SENSEX 77264.51 (-276.32)



IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	24175.65	-76.35
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.47	-0.07
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.37	-0.32
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	158939.00	-1038
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	243892.00	-2738



RULES WITH ROOM.

AI regulation has to be done in a way that it doesn't stifle the industry, says Ganesh Gopalan, CEO, Gnani.ai **p10**

SPARK.

Sustainable packaging start-ups face funding constraints, consolidation and pressure to scale profitably **p8**

MONDAY SPECIALS.

CLEANTECH

There's a lot wrong in the Indian RE sector



New and Renewable Energy Minister Pralhad Joshi never misses an opportunity to dilate on how great things are with the country's renewable energy industry — even though statistics show otherwise. Solar manufacturing capacity expansion seems to be at a frenetic pace, with an estimated ₹1 lakh crore of announced investments. But scratch the surface and a very different picture emerges. **p6**

CORPORATE FILE

Birla vs Adani: Heavy metal face-off

First they clashed over cement. Now, the corporate rivalry between the Aditya Birla Group and Adani Group is shifting to aluminium. Hindalco Industries plans to deploy around ₹50,000 crore in capacity expansion, upstream integration and downstream value-added products, in a bid to strengthen its market position ahead of the Adani Group's entry into the aluminium business. **p7**

'LIC may raise stake in NSE, eyes reach in every panchayat'

TRUST, TECH & REACH. Focuses on digital transformation, last-mile insurance penetration

K Ram Kumar
Mahesh Ravidas Nayak
Mumbai

bl.interview

Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC), one of the largest shareholders in the National Stock Exchange (NSE) with a 10.72 per cent stake, may consider increasing it in the bourse once the much-awaited initial public offering is launched, said its MD & CEO R Doraiswamy in an exclusive interview with *businessline*.

The insurer has already decided against selling shares in the proposed offer-for-sale, signalling confidence in the long-term value of the exchange.

"We have taken a call not to be a seller. We will look at the process, look at the price and then take a call whether to enhance our stake or not," Doraiswamy said, indicating that LIC could emerge as a buyer depending on valuations and market conditions.

"We invest in stocks that have the potential to create long-term value. Our size



The protection business has been witnessing strong growth and is expected to become a larger contributor to LIC's portfolio

R DORAISWAMY
MD & CEO, Life Insurance Corporation of India

also means we can act as a financial institution and market stabiliser," he said.

LIC's long-duration liabilities and large annuity book make it a natural long-term investor, supporting its counter-cyclical approach to equity investments.

RURAL REACH

Even as it evaluates opportunities in capital markets, LIC's biggest operational focus remains expanding insurance penetration across the country. The insurer is aiming to establish representation in every village *panchayat*, building on a network that already covers about 92 per cent of India's districts and nearly 56 per cent of *pan-*



chayats. Doraiswamy said, "We are identifying *panchayats* where there is no LIC agent available and ensuring representation there." LIC expects to make substantial progress towards full *panchayat* coverage in the next one to two years.

The life insurer aims to combine its legacy of trust with a more agile and tech-driven operating model. We need to stay relevant to the current generation by providing solutions that are available at their fingertips," he said.

MARGIN FOCUS

On the business side, LIC is continuing its shift towards higher-margin non-particip-

ating products. The share of non-par products has risen sharply from about 7-8 per cent of annualised premium equivalent at the time of listing to nearly 30 per cent now. "We would like to keep it around 30-35 per cent," he said. The insurer is also increasing its focus on protection products while retaining its strengths in savings and annuity businesses.

"The protection business has been witnessing strong growth and is expected to become a larger contributor to LIC's portfolio," said Doraiswamy.

At the group level, LIC is reviewing the performance of subsidiaries, associate companies and overseas operations to ensure they contribute to profitability.

"We expect them to contribute to the overall profitability," he said.

Businesses failing to meet expectations are being closely evaluated. LIC has already moved its UK operations into run-off mode and is reviewing its Singapore business as part of a broader effort to improve efficiency and returns across the group.

Interview on p9

Cash market volumes fall to five-month low as CAS swings rattle investors

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

The average daily turnover (ADT) on the NSE dipped by ₹3,837 crore, or 3 per cent, in August to ₹1,16,579 crore from ₹1,20,416 crore in July, amid uncertainty surrounding the closing auction session (CAS) and prevailing bearish sentiment in the market.

In fact, the ADT on the NSE fell to a five-month low in August as investors turned cautious amid sharp price volatility and profit-taking. Persistent stake sales by promoters through bulk and block deals, along with robust IPO activity, also dampened investor appetite for the secondary market.

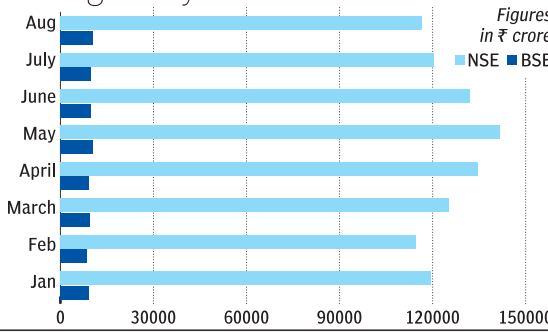
SHARP SWINGS

On August 3, SEBI introduced the CAS to determine the official closing price for eligible stocks in the equity cash segment through a single-price call auction, replacing the earlier 30-minute volume-weighted average price method.

The initial framework covers only 208 F&O-eligible stocks. However, the auction mechanism triggered sharp swings in the share prices of index constituents.

On Wednesday, August 26, the expiry day, the Nifty plunged 272 points within

Average daily turnover in cash market



about 30 seconds of the CAS opening at 3.20 pm, falling from its 3.15 pm reference level of 24,277 points to 24,005 points. The index subsequently recovered and closed at 24,208 by 3.30 pm, just 0.28 per cent below the reference level.

Similarly, the BSE Sensex too recorded its sharpest swing on August 27, its expiry day. After trading above 77,100 until 3.15 pm, the index briefly dropped 2,112 points to 74,988 during CAS before recovering to close at 76,933. A day after the introduction of CAS, equity cash market turnover on the BSE declined 7 per cent to ₹9,508 crore on August 4 from ₹10,264 crore on August 3.

However, turnover recovered, posting an 8 per cent increase in August to ₹10,632 crore from ₹9,870 crore in July.

Former SEBI Chairman

UK Sinha, in an interview with *businessline* said, the market regulator could have spent more time preparing participants before implementing the framework. "Better preparation, consultation, and beta testing were needed, but I am not worried. My sense is that it will stabilise," Sinha said.

Anand James, Chief Market Strategist at Geojit Investments, said that once continuous trading ends at 3.15 pm, uncertainty remains over the final closing price, with options traders largely in the dark during the intervening period. While this may have contributed to the decline in trading volumes, he said it should also be noted that the Nifty had been trending lower through the first half of August and remained largely range-bound.

With inputs from Akshata Gorde

Iran-UAE rift clouds BRICS summit in India

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

The continuing West Asia conflict and divergent positions of Iran and the UAE are casting a shadow over the successful conclusion of the BRICS Summit to be hosted by New Delhi on September 12-13.

India is stepping up efforts to bridge differences among the 11 members and secure agreement on a common joint communique, a senior official said.

The challenge is underlined by the fact that two key BRICS meetings held earlier this year, the Foreign Ministers' and Trade Ministers' meetings, could not produce a joint communique because of differences linked to the West Asia conflict.

"India is now relying on the Sherpa channel, with its representatives in touch with counterparts to narrow



differences ahead of the summit," an official told *businessline*.

"BRICS is a consensus-based framework. Whatever discussions we have, we aim to build consensus through dialogue. As Chair, India's effort has been to maintain dialogue, engagement and discussion among all members on every issue," the official said.

SEEKING REFORMS

India is seeking consensus on issues such as cross-border payments, economic cooperation and reform of multilateral institutions, the

official added. Heads of State from most BRICS countries, including Chinese President Xi Jinping, Russian President Vladimir Putin and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, are expected to attend the meeting. Abu Dhabi Crown Prince Sheikh Khalid bin Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan may represent the UAE.

TRADE EMBARGO

Other members, including Brazil, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Saudi Arabia and Indonesia, will be represented by Heads of State or senior officials. The Iran-UAE differences over the West Asia crisis have been particularly difficult to reconcile. Things nosedived after the UAE announced an indefinite trade embargo on Iran on August 19, accusing Iranian forces of firing two ballistic missiles at its territory. Iran denied the allegation, calling the reported at-

tack a "false flag operation" by Israel and the US.

The official said India's approach was to be "very transparent and inclusive", allowing every member to put forward its views while identifying areas where consensus could be built.

For India, the objective ahead of the September summit is not necessarily to eliminate differences, but to find formulations acceptable to all members and prevent geopolitical disagreements from derailing the broader agenda. "Sherpas are expected to continue intensive consultations in the coming weeks on the draft summit declaration, with India seeking to ensure that the summit ends with a common joint communique — an important indicator of the grouping's ability to maintain unity despite its expanding membership and increasingly divergent national positions," the official said.

GST Council meeting to focus on compliance easing; mobile phone GST rate cut on the cards

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

An overhaul of compliance procedures and a targeted rate cut on mobile phones take centre stage as the GST Council prepares to meet on September 12 after a 374-day hiatus.

While the Council's previous session focused on tax rate rationalisation, the upcoming meeting is expected to prioritise easing compliance burdens for businesses.

Rate adjustments remain on the table, most notably a proposed reduction of the GST on mobile handsets from 18 per cent to a lower bracket, though the official agenda has not yet been circulated.

One of the biggest structural concerns is the inverted duty structure, under which GST paid on inputs can exceed the tax payable on the final product. This has

One of the biggest structural concerns is the inverted duty structure, under which GST paid on inputs can exceed the tax payable on the final product

resulted in the accumulation of credits for manufacturers, textile and pharma and FMCG firms.

"GST 2.0 simplified slabs, but it also deepened the inverted tax problem," said Brijesh Kothary, Partner at Khaitan & Co.

While provisional refunds introduced in Budget 2026 have provided some relief, he said the underlying issue remains because the refund formula does not cover input services. A legislative change to allow refunds of input-ser-

vice credit is therefore required, he said.

The latter concern extends beyond inverted-duty refunds. Vivek Jalan, Partner at Tax Connect Advisory Services, said legal and technology changes are needed to protect genuine recipients of ITC when suppliers fail to discharge their tax liabilities.

He cited the Maruti Enterprises ruling and the Supreme Court's decision in Bhandari Scrap Traders as highlighting the need for greater certainty for compliant taxpayers.

COMPENSATION CESS

Another issue that could require the Council's attention is the fate of accumulated compensation cess. Ranjeet Mahtani, Partner at Dhruva Advisors, said GST 2.0 left some businesses with accumulated cess that was effectively neutralised after the levy was discontinued. He estimated the amount con-

servatively at around ₹6,000 crore.

The automobile sector and coal users have consequently either absorbed the impact, passed it on to consumers or begun litigation seeking an adjustment or liquidation mechanism for the accumulated cess, Mahtani said. The Council would need to devise a mechanism to unlock the amount.

Jalan also flagged the need to make it easier for businesses operating across multiple States to transfer ITC seamlessly between registrations. Rationalisation of blocked credits relating to construction and works contracts, an issue highlighted by the Safari Retreats case, could also come up for consideration.

The September 12 meeting is expected to examine whether the benefits of the previous round of GST rate rationalisation have been passed on to consumers.

E20 fallout: Waiting period for EV, CNG cars stretches up to 6 months ahead of festival season

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Concerns over E20's impact on older petrol engines and festival buying are accelerating demand for electric and alternative-powertrain vehicles faster than manufacturers can supply some models and variants.

Mahindra's XEV 9S faces a waiting period of up to six months, select Tata Punch EV and Tiago EV variants 18-24 weeks and TVS Motor's iQube electric scooter four to five months. Maruti Suzuki's Brezza averages about two months, with its turbo-petrol and CNG variants together accounting for more than 70 per cent of bookings.

The queues are building before festival demand peaks despite dealers carrying about four weeks of passenger-vehicle inventory and four to five weeks of two-wheeler stock. EV and CNG



Shifting preferences leave dealers stocked overall but short on popular variants **p71**

sharply, while supply of some variants customers want has not kept pace," said Vinkesh Gulati, former FADA President and Chairman of the Automotive Skills Development Council.

The shortage can be sharpest at the cheaper end of some EV ranges. Punch EV Smart 30 and Tiago EV variants face waiting period of 18-24 weeks. Sierra EV Pure 65 takes around 12-15 weeks, against four-six weeks for some higher variants. A buyer willing to spend more can therefore get the same nameplate months earlier.

E20 CONCERNS

Motorists' E20 concerns centre on lower mileage and fears of damage to engines in older petrol vehicles. Randheer Singh, former Director, Electric Mobility and Clean Energy at NITI Aayog and Founder & CEO of ForeSee Advisors, however, told *businessline* that owners need not

distress-sell serviceable older vehicles. When replacement makes economic sense, they can consider an E20-optimised petrol vehicle or an EV, with battery-as-a-service schemes lowering upfront cost and battery risk.

The squeeze is visible in Maharashtra too. "Overall inventory may be comfortable, but that does not mean the vehicle a customer wants is immediately available," said Sachin Mahajan, FADA's Maharashtra State Chairman and an automobile dealer. Electric two-wheeler enquiries are growing 30-40 per cent, against 10-12 per cent for the broader market, while iQube waiting period remains four-five months.

The mismatch has emerged before the biggest festival weeks. Onam passenger-vehicle sales in Kerala grew more than 20 per cent y-o-y, with Ganesh Chaturthi, Navratri, Dhanteras and Diwali still ahead.

QUICKLY.

India, Chile aim to conclude trade pact talks

New Delhi: India is committed to conclude negotiations for a comprehensive trade agreement with Chile this year as it would help further strengthen economic ties between the two countries, the Commerce Ministry said. Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal was in Santiago, Chile to review the progress of the talks. The proposed comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEPA) is expected to open new avenues for greater trade and investment.

Keralam's MV Dept to add Aadhaar OTP check

Thiruvananthapuram: Keralam's Motor Vehicles Department will introduce Aadhaar-based OTP verification for 60 more services from September 21 to prevent middlemen from exploiting applicants, officials said. The services, available through the Vahan and Sarathi portals for vehicle and driving licence-related matters, respectively, will be brought online under the initiative.

Gas-based power plants stabilised grid during nights in Apr-May: IGU

HEAT IS ON. Peak power demand reached a record 271 GW due to severe heat waves

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

India's gas-based power plants helped provide grid stability during the peak electricity demand season in April and May 2026 as severe heat waves pushed up demand for cooling during evening and night hours.

India has 20 GW of gas-based power plants as of July 2026. The International Gas Union (IGU) noted that India provides a recent example of how heat waves can translate into higher gas demand.

In May 2026, peak power demand reached a record 271 GW as severe heat waves lifted cooling needs across the country.

During April and May, natural gas-based power plants increased natural gas purchases on the Indian Gas Exchange (IGX) by around 340 per cent y-o-y, reaching 124.3 million cubic meters



GRID RESILIENCE. India has 20 gigawatts (GW) of gas-based power plants as of July 2026

(mcm), it pointed out. "While solar helped meet daytime demand, natural gas-based plants provided flexible supply and supported grid stability during high demand evening and night hours when solar generation was unavailable. This shows how natural gas can provide short term flexibility when extreme heat pushes electricity demand above normal levels," the industry body emphasised.

It highlighted that cooling needs during periods of ex-

treme heat are increasing the need for reliable and dispatchable power, particularly where grid capacity, renewable output or storage availability are constrained.

SYSTEM FLEXIBILITY In this context, natural gas can support system flexibility by providing capacity during periods of high demand, supply disruption or lower renewable generation, IGU noted. Electricity demand growth is being driven by several factors including

cooling, industrial activity, agriculture and broader economic growth. However, hotter seasonal conditions can add further pressures by increasing cooling needs.

For instance, in India, the monthly peak demand rose above historical ranges during the 2026 hot season, with the country staying above the 2020-2024 range in the first five months of the year. It reported daytime peak power demand of a record 270 GW during May and July, it added.

The industry body emphasised that higher maximum daily temperatures go hand in hand with rising air-conditioning ownership, supported by income growth, urbanisation and improving living standards.

"Peak demand during cooling seasons has become more sensitive to temperature as air-conditioner stock continues to grow. In India, each 1°C increase in outdoor temperature was associated

with more than 7 GW of additional peak demand in 2024, up from around 4 GW in 2019," IGU said.

This points to a wider risk for fast growing Asian markets, where expanding cooling access can turn short periods of extreme heat into system wide demand spikes, it said.

PLANNING CHALLENGE These developments point to a broader planning challenge. As air-conditioning use rises, higher temperatures can widen the gap between average electricity demand and peak demand. This shows that heatwave-driven demand growth is not only a short-term operational issue, but also a long-term capacity planning challenge, the industry body emphasised.

"Looking ahead, the risk could become more pronounced in 2026 if El Niño conditions develop as expected," the IGU said.

SEBI could have been better prepared for closing auction: Ex-chief UK Sinha

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai



Former SEBI Chairman UK Sinha

Former Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) Chairman UK Sinha said the market regulator could have been better prepared before rolling out the closing auction session (CAS), as the new market mechanism faces concerns over liquidity and sharp price swings.

"Better preparation, consultation, and beta testing were needed, but I am not worried. My sense is that it will stabilise," Sinha told *businessline*.

The closing auction mechanism, introduced on August 3 for stocks in the futures and options (F&O) segment, changed the way their official closing prices are determined. Continuous trading in these stocks now ends at 3.15 pm, followed by an auction process to arrive at the closing price.

The regulator had issued two consultation papers on the proposal before finalising the framework in January. However, the exchanges conducted a CAS-specific mock trading session only on August 1, two days before the mechanism went live.

tempts at manipulation easier to identify.

"Perhaps there could have been wider preparation, but it will eventually stabilise. But if there is anybody trying to manipulate, their chances of getting caught are very high now," Sinha said, adding that an active securities lending and borrowing mechanism would've made the transition smoother.

Last week, SEBI also acted against entities for alleged manipulation in the cash market by placing large orders during the auction to benefit from their derivatives expiry positions.

INHERENT MISMATCH

The experience has also brought into focus the disconnect between the size of the derivatives market and the underlying cash market. Large derivatives positions are settled based on prices discovered in a cash market with relatively smaller trading volumes, risking market stability.

SEBI had taken a series of steps over the past two years to curb excessive speculation in the derivatives space, including changes to contract sizes and incentives for deepening cash market volumes.

Sinha backed the regulator's approach, saying that trading in futures and options was inherently risky for individuals who may not fully understand leverage.

Domestic lines worried as govt lets foreign vessels in coastal trade

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

India's shipping industry is set for continued competition from foreign-flagged vessels in coastal trade, with the Centre restoring the 2018 relaxations to ensure capacity for exporters and importers amid geopolitical disruptions.

The Shipping Ministry, through an order on August 10, has restored relaxations allowing foreign-flagged vessels to carry specified categories of cargo between Indian ports, opting for continuity amid geopolitical disruptions and capacity constraints in global shipping.

ping. The Ministry's order of August has rescinded two orders issued in January reversing the 2018 relaxations that had provided foreign shipping lines a transition period to comply with the stricter cabotage regime.

LATEST ORDER

The Ministry said the withdrawal of the January and March orders till September was intended to provide policy stability and operational certainty to India's maritime trade and logistics sector at a time when geopolitical developments were disrupting global shipping.

Jagannarayan Padmanabhan, Senior Director and

Global Head-Consulting, Crisil Intelligence, said the decision "essentially maintains continuity and *status quo*" for shippers and shipping companies and avoids another regulatory transition.

NO EXCLUSIVE ACCESS

For Indian-flagged shipping companies, however, the decision means they will not get exclusive access to the eligible coastal cargo and will continue to compete with foreign carriers, he added.

Maritime trade expert Rajesh Menon said retaining the arrangement was necessary to ensure adequate availability of ships for In-



dia's export-import trade.

"Since the geopolitical situation is grim, there should be availability of ships. Hence, the *status quo* of allowing foreign vessels in coastal trade needs to be

maintained," he said.

A former official of the department wondered, "If after a thorough review involving stakeholders, it is determined by the competent authority that the 2018 orders have not served their intended purpose and have accordingly been withdrawn duly, it is a matter of public concern that the same orders that have been regarded as worthless by the Government's own elaborate review process, are sought to be given a fresh lease of life for no ostensible reason than vaguely stating it is for 'policy stability and operational certainty to safeguard India's maritime and logistics sectors.'"

Indian Bank to add 100 branches in FY27

Press Trust of India
Chennai

Indian Bank plans to add about 100 branches this year, with a focus on increasing presence in the central and western parts of the country. It will also increase its headcount by about 2,500 personnel, including specialist officers.

"Last year we opened 100 branches. This year too we have similar plans. Just on August 15, which was our foundation day, the bank inaugurated 15 branches across the country," Indian Bank MD and CEO Binod Kumar told *PTI*.

AP CM to launch Veligonda irrigation project

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

The first phase of the long-awaited Veligonda irrigation project will be inaugurated today bringing Krishna waters into the drought-prone region.

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu will open the project.

With the inauguration of Phase-I, Over 10.70 TMC of Krishna water will be released into Nallamala Sagar. The first phase is aimed at providing irrigation to around 1.19 lakh acres and drinking water to approximately four lakh people.

The State government is organising the inauguration under the theme *Veligonda*

Jalasirulu - Abhivruddhiki Rekkalu (Veligonda's Water Wealth - Wings to Development). Naidu had laid the foundation stone for the project on March 5, 1996, as the Chief Minister of undivided Andhra Pradesh.

Once fully operational, the project is expected to provide irrigation to 4.47 lakh acres across the four districts and 23 lakh people.



Malabar Regional Co-operative Milk Producers' Union Ltd.
H.O. Perungudi, Kumbakonam (TN), Kozhikode - 673571
Kerala, Ph: 0495-2805413, 2805405, 2805408
Email: mrcmpu@malabarmilma.coop

RE - E - TENDER NOTICE
MRU/PA/322/ 2026-27 29-08-2026

Re - E-tenders are invited from eligible Agencies/Parties for the Supply of **Green Maize Fodder and Baled Maize Silage wrapped with plastic film (50 Kg bale type)** to the various Dairy Co-operative Societies under MRCMPU Ltd., For more details visit www.malabarmilma.com, www.etenders.kerala.gov.in E-Tender Id: **2026_KCMMF 863617_2, 2026_KCMMF 863707_2**, Last Date: 08.09.2026, 17:30 Hrs.

(Sd/-) Managing Director



MANOJVAIBHAVGEMS N' JEWELLERS LIMITED

Registered Office: 47-15-B, V Square, Zone-A, Opp: TSR Complex, Station Road, Dwarakanagar, Visakhapatnam, 530016, Andhra Pradesh.
Corporate Office: 47-10-19, 2nd Lane, Dwarakanagar, Visakhapatnam, 530016, Andhra Pradesh, CIN: L55101AP1989PLC009734, Phone no: 8916637777
• Email: cs@vaibhavjewellers.com • Website: www.vaibhavjewellers.com

NOTICE TO EQUITY SHAREHOLDERS REGARDING 37th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING

Shareholders are hereby informed that the 37th Annual General Meeting ("AGM") of Manoj Vaibhav Gems 'N' Jewellers Limited ("Company") will be held on Friday, September 25, 2026 at 12:00 noon through Video Conference ("VC") / Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM") in compliance with the applicable provisions of Companies Act, 2013 ("Act") and rules framed thereunder and the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("Listing Regulations") read with General Circular 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025 issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") and other applicable Circulars issued in this regard by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") and the Securities Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") (hereinafter collectively referred to as "the circulars"), to transact the businesses that will be set forth in the 37th Notice of the AGM.

In compliance with the above mentioned circulars read with other relevant circulars issued by MCA and SEBI from time to time, the electronic copy of the Notice convening 37th AGM along with detailed instructions for E-Voting and Annual Report will be sent through electronic mode to all the Shareholders of the Company whose email addresses are registered with the Company/Depository Participants/Registrar & Share Transfer Agent ("RTA") of the Company. Members holding shares in demat form may contact their respective Depository Participants (DPs) for registration / updation of their email addresses. As on March 31, 2026, all Equity shares of the Company are in dematerialized form.

The Notice of the AGM and Annual Report will also be available on the website of the Company i.e., www.vaibhavjewellers.com and the Stock Exchanges where the shares of the Company are listed i.e., BSE Limited and National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com respectively and on the website of Central Depository Services Limited (agency for providing the Remote e-Voting facility and e-voting system during the AGM) i.e., www.evotingindia.com.

Members will be able to join the 37th AGM through VC/OAVM facility only.

The Company will provide remote e-voting facility to Members. The instructions for joining the AGM and manner for casting votes through remote e-voting as well as e-voting system during the AGM will be provided in the Notice of the 37th AGM.

For Manoj Vaibhav Gems 'N' Jewellers Limited
Sd/-
Place: Visakhapatnam
Date: 29-08-2026

Mrs. Bharata Mallika Ratna Kumari Grandhi
Chairperson & Managing Director
DIN: 00492520



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102nd ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING (AGM) TO BE HELD THROUGH VC / OAVM

Notice is hereby given that the **102nd Annual General Meeting (AGM)** of the Members of The Karnataka Bank Limited will be convened on **Tuesday, September 22, 2026 at 11.00 A.M.** through Video Conferencing (VC) / Other Audio Visual Means (OAVM) facility to transact the business, as set out in the Notice of the 102nd AGM, in compliance with the applicable provisions of the SEBI (Listing Obligations & Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 and Companies Act, 2013 and Rules framed thereunder read with General Circular No.: 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025, and SEBI Circular dated October 03, 2024 for conducting AGM without the physical presence of Members at a common venue.

The Notice of the 102nd AGM along with the Annual Report will be sent in due course through electronic mode only, to the Members of the Bank whose email addresses are registered with the Depository Participant / Registrar & Share Transfer Agent (RTA). The Notice of the 102nd AGM and Annual Report for Financial Year 2025-26 will also be made available on the website of the Bank at <https://karnatakabank.bank.in/investors> and on the website of CDSL at www.evotingindia.com. Additionally, the notice of AGM and Annual Report will also be available on the website of the Stock Exchanges i.e., BSE Limited (BSE) and National Stock Exchange of India Limited (NSE) at www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com respectively.

Members can attend and participate in the 102nd AGM through VC / OAVM facility only. The Bank will be providing remote e-voting facility to all its members to cast their votes before the date of AGM on the resolutions set out in the Notice of the AGM and also e-voting facility during the AGM. The detailed instructions / procedure with respect to participation and e-voting will be provided in the Notice convening the Meeting. Members attending the meeting through VC / OAVM shall be counted for the purpose of quorum in terms of Section 103 of the Companies Act, 2013.

Members are requested to contact their Depository Participant and register their email address and bank account details in their demat account as per the process of the respective Depository Participant.

Dividend Record Date

The Board of Directors at their meeting held on Tuesday, May 19, 2026, recommended dividend at the rate of **₹5.00/-** per equity share having face value of ₹10/- each for the Financial Year ended March 31, 2026. The record date for the purpose of the dividend is **September 15, 2026**.

The dividend once declared by the shareholders in the 102nd AGM will be paid to those shareholders whose name appear in the Bank's Register of Members / Statement of Beneficial Position received from the NSDL and the CDSL as at the close of business hours on **September 15, 2026**. To avoid the delay in receiving dividend, Members are requested to update their KYC with their depositories; (where shares are held in dematerialized mode) and with the Registrar & Share Transfer Agent of the Bank (where shares are held in physical mode) to receive dividend directly to their bank account. All future dividend payments shall be made only through electronic mode of payment approved by the Reserve Bank of India and the Bank will not be paying dividend(s) through physical mode i.e., 'Dividend Warrants'.

Members may note that the Income Tax Act 2025, ("the IT Act") mandates that dividends paid or distributed by the Company shall be taxable in the hands of Members. The Bank shall therefore be required to deduct tax at source ("TDS") at the time of making the payment of the final dividend. To enable us to determine the appropriate TDS rate as applicable, Members are requested to submit relevant documents in accordance with the provisions of the IT Act on or before **September 17, 2026**. In this regard, a separate email is being sent to the Members whose email address is registered with the depositories and also to the physical shareholders who have registered their e-mail addresses explaining the process of withholding of tax at prescribed rates on dividend being paid to the Members. For more information, members may contact Registrar & Share Transfer Agent of the Bank, Integrated Registry Management Services Private Limited, Unit: The Karnataka Bank Limited, No. 30, Ramana Residency, 4th Cross, Sampige Road, Malleshwaram, Bengaluru-560003, Fax: (080) 23460819, Email: irg@integratedindia.in or call Tel: (080) 23460815-818.

By the Order of the Board of Directors
For The Karnataka Bank Limited
Sd/-
Sham K
Company Secretary

Place: Mangaluru
Date : 31.08.2026

 ERNAKULAM REGIONAL CO-OPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS' UNION LTD. ERNAKULAM DAIRY, TRIPUNITHURA-682301, Ph: 0484-2781694, email: ercnpuedengg@milma.com			
No. ED/E&M/44.81.6/2026-27			29.08.2026
RE-E-TENDER NOTICE			
Title	E-tender ID	Bid closing	
SITC of Rotary Oven and supply of additional trolleys for Muvattupuzha Bakery & Confectionery Unit	2026_KCMMF_864937_2	07.09.2026, 03.00 pm	
SITC of UV sterilizer for existing water line	2026_KCMMF_864947_2	07.09.2026, 03.30 pm	
Electrical maintenance works	2026_KCMMF_864980_2	08.09.2026, 01.00 pm	
For NIT, visit www.etenders.kerala.gov.in		(Sd/-) Senior Manager /c	



**पावरग्रिड
POWERGRID**

- Petition for determination of tariff for Asset-1: 05 Nos 200 kV Bays, 02 Nos 220kV Transfer bus coupler bays and 01 no 220kV Bus coupler bay at Kurnool-III Pooling Station, Asset-2: 1x500MVA, 400/220kV ICT(5th) along with associated bays at Kurnool-III Pooling Station Asset-3: 765 kV Kurnool III- Maheshwaram (PG) D/C Line with 2x240MVAR switchable line Reactors at both ends along with associated bays and equipments under "Transmission System for Kurnool Wind Energy Zone/Solar Energy Zone(AP) - Part-A & Part-B" in Southern Region under Section 62 read with Section 79(1)(d) of Electricity Act, 2003 and under the Regulation 15(1)(a) and Regulation 23 of Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (Conduct of Business) Regulations, 2023 read with Central Electricity Regulatory Commission (Terms and Condition of Tariff Regulations),2024.
The beneficiaries of the above-mentioned Transmission system are: (a) TANGEDCO (b) TSNPDCL (c) KSEBL (d) TNPDCL (e) Electricity Dept. of Goa (f) Electricity Dept. of Puducherry (g) APEDCL (h) APSPDCL (i) CESC (j) MESCOM (k) BESCOM (l) GESCOM (m) HESCOM (n) APCPDCL & (o) CTUIL.
- Tariff details:

Name of the Asset	Establishment of 765/400/220 kV Substation at Kurnool-III, Extension of 765 kV Kurnool (New) substation, and 765 kV Kurnool-III-Kurnool (New) D/C Line		
Asset	Asset-1	Asset-2	Asset-3
Schedule DOCO (FR)	02.11.2024		
DOCO	31.05.2025 (Proposed)	01.11.2026	27.05.2026
FR Approved cost (Rs in Lakhs)	2827.47	5141.15	192488.11
Estimated Completion Cost (Rs in Lakhs)	2777.44	5047.87	195066.42
Tariff for the year (Rs in Lakhs)			
2024-25	-	-	-
2025-26	402.52	347.75	-
2026-27	528.22	927.28	22849.49
2027-28	536.06	944.54	28068.90
2028-29	532.88	940.73	28312.72

- A copy of the application made for determination of tariff is posted on the website of the applicant at www.powergrid.in.
- The suggestions and objections, if any, on the proposals for determination of tariff contained in the application be filed by any person, including the beneficiary before the Secretary, Central Electricity Regulatory Commission 6th, 7th & 8th Floors, Tower B, World Trade Centre, Nauroji Nagar, New Delhi-110029 (or other address where the office of the Commission is situated), with a copy to the applicant at the address of its corporate office within 30 days of publication of this notice.

Place: Gurgaon
Date: 30.08.2026

Sd/-
DGM (Commercial)

POWER GRID CORPORATION OF INDIA LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)
Registered Office: B-9, Outub Institutional Area, Katwaria Sarai, New Delhi 110 016
Corporate Office: Saudamini, Plot No.2, Sector-29, Gurgaon, Haryana - 122 001
www.powergrid.in, CIN: L40101DL1989GOI038121

A MAHARATNA PSU

India’s GDP growth seen at 7-7.5% in Q1; SBI Research estimates 8%

CAUTIOUS OPTIMISM. Momentum is positive, yet weather and fuel demand pose risks, say economists

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Indian economy is likely to have grown between 7 and 7.5 per cent during the April-June quarter (Q1) of the current fiscal, various research reports indicated. SBI Research is an outlier, expecting the growth rate to touch 8 per cent.

The Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) will formally release the data on Monday. The growth rate during the January-March quarter (Q4) of 2025-26 was 7.8 per cent, while it was 6.8 per cent in the April-June quarter (Q1) of FY26. Q1 of FY27 is the first full quarter after the war began in West Asia.

Barclays estimated the growth rate at 7.5 per cent. High-frequency activity indicators (HFIs) for April-June saw better growth rates versus the January-March

STRONG START

- Govt capex, credit growth support momentum ahead
- Agriculture growth seen at 3.5 per cent
- Industrial activity satisfactory barring few pockets
- Consumption demand remains resilient, services support growth



quarter. “Out of the 20 HFIs we track, only seven saw y-o-y average growth rates slow in Q1FY27 versus Q4FY26,” said Aastha Gudwani, India Chief Economist at Barclays.

Of these seven, indicators such as petrol, diesel, LPG demand and fertilizer production were anticipated to see slower growth, reeling under the stress of the West Asia conflict. Steel production growth slowed, two-wheeler production slowed too but remained quite ro-

bust. Though Jahnavi Prabhakar, Economist at Bank of Baroda, shared optimism with Gudwani, her projection is on the lower side.

“India’s GDP is estimated to grow by 7 per cent in Q1FY27,” Prabhakar said.

The agriculture sector is expected to register a growth of 3.5 per cent compared with a growth of 4.4 per cent in the corresponding period last year.

The slower growth is on account of extreme heat-

wave conditions, prevalence of El Nino conditions, delayed onslaught of the south-west monsoon and lower reservoir levels witnessed during this quarter.

HEALTHY CREDIT

According to Prabhakar, apart from better industrial performance, steady improvement in government capex along with healthy credit and deposit growth will push growth higher.

“Going ahead for FY27, growth is projected at 6.6-6.8 per cent, as more clarity emerges on account of conflict resolution in West Asia as well as the final outcome of kharif harvest,” she said.

Meanwhile, SBI’s economic research report has expected growth to be higher on both sequential and y-o-y basis.

“Our Q1FY27 GDP growth estimate stands at 8 per cent,” Soumya Kanti Ghosh, Group Chief Eco-

nomics Adviser of SBI, wrote in the report.

He explained that the underlying momentum remains broad-based.

“We track more than 50 leading indicators across consumption and demand, agriculture, industry, services and other sectors, with 86 per cent showing acceleration in Q1 FY27,” he said.

Further, consumption and demand remain resilient. “High-frequency demand indicators continue to support growth outlook, while industrial activity remains broadly satisfactory barring a few pockets while services provide further support, other indicators also corroborate our 8 per cent growth estimate,” he said.

thehindu**businessline.**

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TODAY’S PICK.

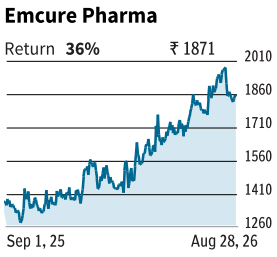
Emcure Pharmaceuticals (₹1,871.25): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

The stock of Emcure Pharmaceuticals has been in a long-term uptrend. After hitting a high of ₹2,047.40 on August 10, the price dropped.

Nevertheless, the broader rally is intact as key support levels stay valid. Notable support levels are ₹1,850 and ₹1,780. As long as these levels hold, the outlook will be positive. Therefore, we expect the stock to resume the rally either from the current level of ₹1,871 or after a decline to ₹1,780.

Before the end of this year, the scrip can appreciate to ₹2,100. So, go long at ₹1,871



and accumulate at ₹1,800. Place stop-loss at ₹1,720. When the stock rallies to ₹2,000 and ₹2,050, alter the stop-loss to ₹1,925 and ₹2,000 respectively. Book profits at ₹2,100.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Think tank calls for review of quality control orders

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Economic think tank GTRI on Sunday called for review of quality control orders (QCOs) to ensure these norms protect consumers without becoming import restrictions or licensing barriers.

Mandatory quality certification under these orders raises costs, hurts MSMEs and makes goods more expensive, the Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) said. It added that if other countries adopt similar orders, Indian exporters could be forced to obtain separate

country-specific certifications, and bear huge travelling and per-diem costs for visiting officers, licensing, renewal and testing fees.

This would raise export costs, delay shipments and create new barriers to trade, GTRI Founder Ajay Srivastava said.

businessline.

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Govt broadens digital fertilizer network linking farmers, subsidies, supply chains

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The government on Sunday said it is broadening a nationwide digital platform that tracks fertilizer from production to retail sale, adding tools to link purchases with individual farmers’ land records and to monitor subsidy payments more closely.

The Integrated Fertilizer Management System (iFMS), run by the Department of Fertilizers with technical support from the National Informatics

Centre, tracks more than 14 crore Aadhaar-linked buyers and over 2,50,000 retailers, and processes about 70 million tonnes of fertilizer sales a year. The system underpins roughly ₹2 lakh crore in annual fertilizer subsidies.

NEW DASHBOARDS

The department has been developing new dashboards that give officials a consolidated view of production, imports, dispatches, stocks and retail sales at the national, state, district and retailer level, an official statement said.

Building on that work, the

department has rolled out a framework for fertilizer sale that links a mobile booking app to the existing point-of-sale network. Under the framework, farmers book fertilizer using an AgriStack-based ID after their land and ownership details are verified, generating a QR code that retailers scan to compare requested and purchased quantities.

Officials say the data will allow analysis of fertilizer use per hectare, by landholding size, crop and product, and of gaps between what farmers say they need and what they buy.

TATA
mutual fund

NOTICE

Unitholders are hereby informed about the declaration of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal under the Monthly Payout / Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option* of the following scheme. The record date for the same is 02 September, 2026.

Schemes - Plan / Option Name	Gross income distribution cum capital withdrawal amount per unit (Rs.) **	Face value per unit (₹)	NAV (₹) as on 27 Aug, 26
Tata Aggressive Hybrid Fund - Direct Plan*	0.82	10.00	99.3877
Tata Aggressive Hybrid Fund - Regular Plan*	0.82	10.00	82.0013

***(Monthly Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is not assured & is subject to the availability of distributable surplus).**

Pursuant to payment of Income Distribution cum capital withdrawal, the NAV of the scheme would fall to the extent of the payout & statutory levy (if applicable).

Unitholders kindly note that amounts are distributed out of investors capital (i.e., Equalisation Reserve), which is part of sale price of the unit that represents realized gains.

**** Payment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is subject to Tax deducted at source (TDS) at applicable rates and other statutory levies if any. Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal is subject to availability & adequacy of distributable surplus on the record date.**

All unitholders holding units under the above-mentioned option of the scheme as at close of business hours, on the record date shall be eligible for Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal.

Considering the volatile nature of markets, the Trustees reserves the right to restrict the quantum of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal upto the per unit distributable surplus available on the record date in case of fall in the market.

Applicable for units held in non-demat form: Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal will be paid to those Unitholders whose names appear in the Register of Unitholders under the Payout /Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option of the aforesaid plan as on record date. These payouts would be done to the last bank/address details updated in our records.

Applicable for units held in demat form: Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal will be paid to those Unitholders/Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories under the Payout/Reinvestment of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal option of the aforesaid plan as on record date. These payouts would be done to the last bank/address details updated in Depository Participant(s) records.

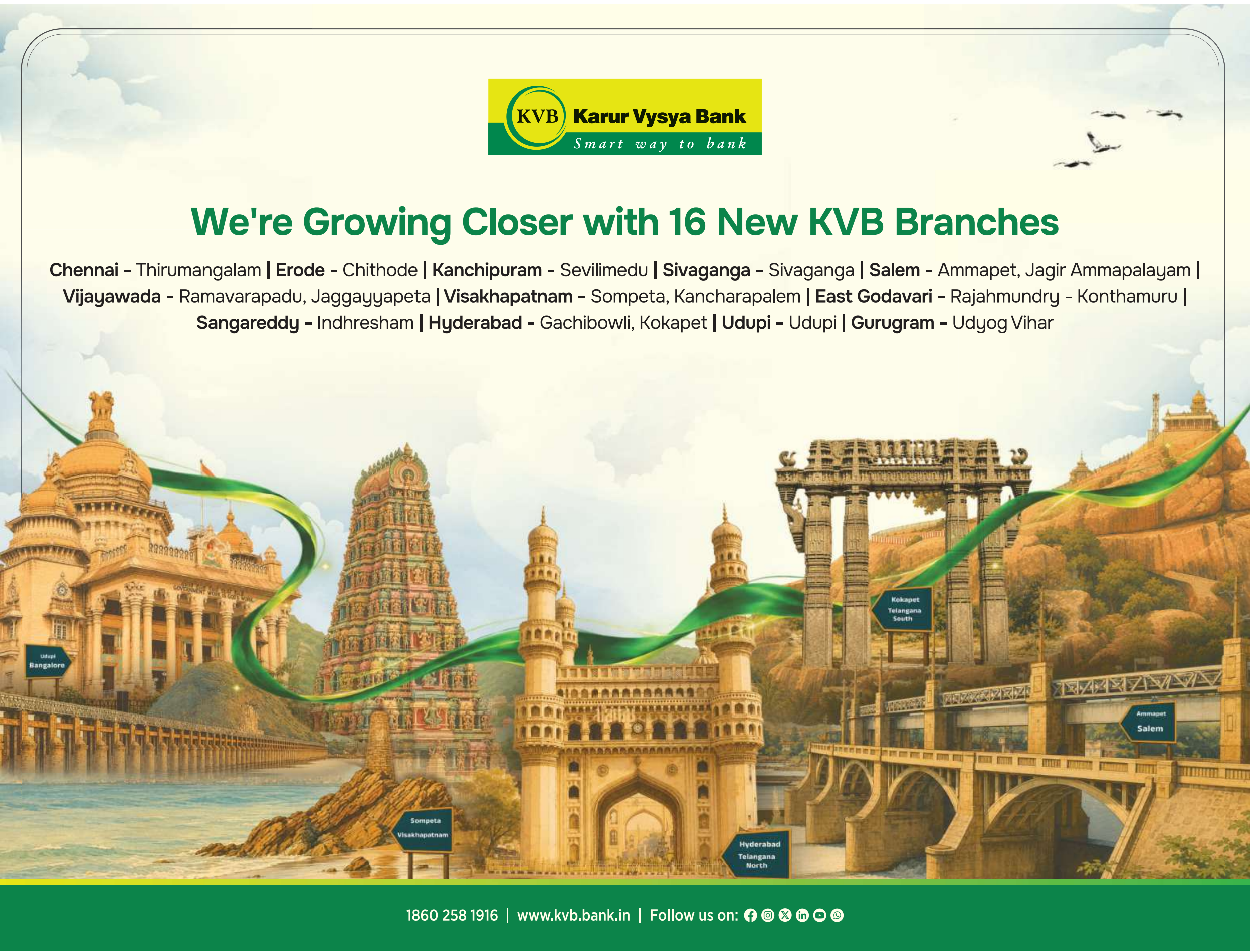
Mutual Fund Investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.



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Central and State drug regulators have started issuing public alerts on products that are not fit for consumption. This process needs to be implemented with greater intent for recalled products, as a standard operating procedure — irrespective of the product’s “criticality”. For companies to claim they have alerted distributors and may not have visibility on the last mile is no argument. The company and the drug regulator should ensure the supply chain and the public are prevented from using the faulty product. The Centre has called for all supply chain entities to be digitally connected – so companies and regulators can track products and inform the network of distributors, stockists and retailers, in minutes. Consumers can be informed of recalls through instant messaging — a process used by aviation and food delivery companies. The rules must be re-examined, if necessary to clearly spell out the responsibilities of producers with respect to recall, and the punitive consequences of lapses in this regard.

The Guardian

On the campaign trail in Makerfield, Andy Burnham told a democracy activist that he favoured a political donations cap of around £500,000 and wanted it reduced over time. His government is now resisting amendments that would move in precisely that direction. Mr Burnham was right in May. He is wrong now. It is difficult to argue that restricting a single person to giving half a million pounds a year to a political party would damage democracy. Such a cap would only affect the mega-rich. Reducing the cap would force parties to wean themselves off the present regime that allows the rich too much say. There are two contra arguments swilling around Labour. The first is that there should be room for wealthy, progressive donors – whose cash helps rebut claims that Labour is in the pocket of the trade unions. LONDON, AUGUST 28

In response to the evident need for a more just and equitable global governance system, President Xi Jinping put forward the Global Governance Initiative at last year's "Shanghai Cooperation Organization Plus" Meeting in Tianjin. The theme of this year's SCO Summit in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan — "Together Toward Sustainable Peace, Development and Prosperity" — and its agenda highlight that the organization can help put the GGI into practice. Xi is attending the SCO Summit 2026 and paying state visits to Kyrgyzstan and Egypt from Sunday to Thursday. The SCO's thriving development over the past 25 years demonstrates the appeal of a new type of international relations based on multilateralism and cooperation rather than unilateralism and bloc confrontation.

BEIJING, AUGUST 30

dangerously off-course, BPCL quickly issued a clarification to put the brakes on the rumours, stating firmly that there is absolutely no proposal to switch back to E10. The company reiterated that after three years and millions of vehicles E20 hasn't caused any engine damage. Instead, it turned the narrative towards reduction in pollution, rural wealth boost, and foreign exchange savings. For now, the government is holding firm on its green mandate, leaving oil PSUs to carefully manage the public relations part.

Instead of a smooth ride, the E20

Behind the curtains

The author’s stormy ties with Bollywood stars

BOOK REVIEW.

Naveen Chandra

How do you walk the tightrope between flying with a Bollywood star in his private jet, spending many nights at the actor’s house with biryani and beer flowing, attending the actor’s wedding and then pen a negative review of the actor’s film upon its release? How do you write a scoop with some inside information about the star and in the same breath, request him for an interview for the Sunday magazine?

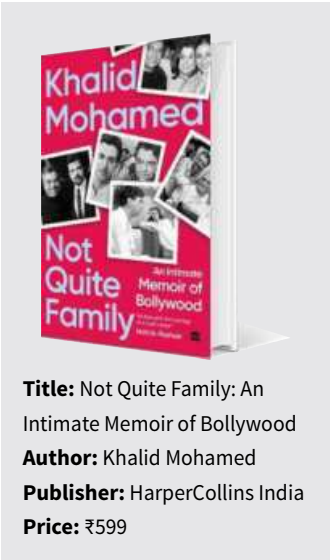
Ask Khalid Mohamed. Having burnt all his bridges in the 30-odd years that he worked as a film journalist, critic and reviewer, he has written a tell-all book on the love-hate relationship he has had with Bollywood film stars.

The bitter sarcasm reflects all through the book, beginning with its title: *Not Quite Family*. In his early days as a film reporter for the *Times of India*, he developed a rapport with stars like Dilip Kumar, Amitabh Bachchan, Sridevi and others and he was welcomed as if he were part of their family. The intense, shared familiarity he shared with everyone would suddenly turn into ignominy, often permanently, when he wrote an unfavourable review of a film, denied them an award, or spilled news he wasn’t supposed to.

The longest chapter and the most sympathetic pages in the book are reserved for Smita Patil, whom he called Smee affectionately. He writes of her solitary life, her clandestine affairs, her angst at navigating the industry alone, her distress when people rated Shabana Azmi as a better actress even though she won the National Award for *Bhumika* and of her sudden, early death. He says he felt it improper to report everything Smita Patil would confess to him during their long, nightly rides to Navy Nagar or to Aarey Milk Colony.

KEEPING A DISTANCE

Two things are evident in the book: a consistent bitter tone when writing about the Bachchans that simmers under the text and the memory of his mother, which comes up every so often. Ironically, after spending a lifetime as an insider in the industry, Khalid chooses to distance himself from Bollywood, saying that the film business isn’t his world as it is petty, unprofessional, and



Title: Not Quite Family: An Intimate Memoir of Bollywood
Author: Khalid Mohamed
Publisher: HarperCollins India
Price: ₹599

soul-deadening. He names people who are yet to pay him his fees for writing or directing their films. Khalid has always written well. His reviews were a mix of inventive word play and sharp, acerbic opinions. He brings that skill to the book. Sample this: “Vaulted ambitions to write scripts and direct films were swimming in my chlorinated head.”

As the editor, he was accused of a Muslim bias whenever any of the Khans won the Filmfare award. Calling Shah Rukh an angel of contradictions, Khalid is unsure whether SRK means everything he says. His close friendship with the star ended when he reported the news of his third child through surrogacy before it became public.

The book is full of Icarian examples of his life in Mumbai’s film world. Like being invited to the pre-wedding celebrations at an actor’s house and dancing the night away, only to be spewed with venom and receive no invitation to the wedding a few weeks later when he critiqued the actor’s performance in a film.

A film journalist’s career is like a storm tossed boat. Throughout the book, Khalid expresses bitterness about spending a life warming the cockles of Bollywood only to be out in the cold now, uninvited and unacknowledged. A few stars he worked with in his films *Fiza* and *Silsila* still stay in touch. The kind of experiences he cites would have broken anyone, but to Khalid’s credit he survived for 30 years. If you need straight, no holds barred insider stories of Bollywood, Khalid’s book has plenty.

The reviewer runs 91 Film Studios, that produces and distributes feature films in regional languages

Turkey’s authoritarian turn

Suzy Hansen presents a gripping portrait of a crisis-ridden Turkey and its impact on the Middle East and the world beyond

BOOK REVIEW.

Atul K Thakur

Pulitzer Prize finalist Suzy Hansen in her book *From Life Itself – Turkey and Istanbul in the Age of Erdogan* presents a gripping portrait of a crisis-ridden Turkey in the backdrop of a global unravelling and deepening fault lines. Recep Tayyip Erdogan, who has been ruling Turkey since 2003 (as Prime Minister from 2003-14; and President from 2014 after pushing through for a major constitutional change for a presidential system) has remade Turkey in his own image.

The book chronicles Turkey’s shift — from once being a shining portal that straddled the cultures of the East and West to a place where its streets swarm with narrow nationalistic fervour. The book is all about this shift as well as the global unravelling at large that is keeping the world order unstable and challenged.

Hansen’s search for truth about modern Turkey is through a deep dive into one single neighbourhood — the Ottoman neighbourhood of Karagümrük. Through its inhabitants and their everyday lives, Hansen shows how local conflicts are spiralling into regional and international crises, deepening the grave fault lines now fracturing Europe, Middle East and West Asia in unprecedented ways.

AUTHORITARIAN IMPULSE

Her book offers a dazzling account of a foundational civilizational nation that once effectively bridged Europe and Asia, serving as a historic crossroads for human society, diverse cultures and empires. Notably, Erdogan came to power as a liberaliser with promises of

greater social, political and economic reforms. Once he succeeded in ingraining his belief system at a mass level with his “Justice and Development Party (Adalet ve Kalkinma Partisi (AKP))”, he cracked down on dissent and following the expansion of his presidential powers in 2018, he has been regarded as authoritarian and unwilling to relinquish power.

Cihan Tugal’s quote at the beginning of the book’s Part-III says it all, “In the early twentieth century, the main political momentum was democracy. In the late neo-liberal era, it is autocracy”. On page-180, Hansen makes an important point on the radical thinking and action of Erdogan. “Now Istanbul was also being transformed by globalisation and global capital. Erdogan’s obsession with remaking the city was not only about money, though that was a lot of it. It was about how Erdogan envisioned a whole new country. His conceptual framework for eradicating Kemalism in Turkish society, while still celebrating Turkishness, Turkish Islam, and Turkey’s Eastern roots, involved an emphasis of the Ottoman Empire, Turkey’s Imperial history, and its caliphate-like role as guardian for the entire Arab Middle East.”

Keeping her narrative rational and free from any forced nostalgia, Hansen says, “The idea that Turkey became more authoritarian during his reign was the flaw in the conventional narrative about Erdogan. Autocracy always ran through Turkey’s politics and state structure, from Ottoman times to Atatürk’s one-party rule to the long twentieth century of its military interference. What Turkey’s experience shows is that countries ostensibly democratic have much deeper autocratic or repressive underpinnings than they like to acknowledge (Page 314).”

The book is majorly about Erdogan



Title: From Life Itself – Turkey and Istanbul in the Age of Erdoğan
Author: Suzy Hansen
Publisher: Hachette India
Price: ₹599

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Suzy Hansen lived in Istanbul for more than a decade, where she was a contributing writer for The New York Times Magazine and many other publications. Her first book, Notes on a Foreign Country, was a finalist for the Pulitzer Prize in Nonfiction

and Turkey’s changed profile in the last two decades, but it also deals with the bitter truth of our time — how an adulterated democratic culture can cast its dark shadow over humanity.

In this shattered Middle East, Erdogan has situated Turkey in a ‘post western’ position.

The book concludes with a query that can haunt people in Turkey and beyond its boundary: What happened to the

opposition during these long two decades? As a reference document, a report (*The Crisis of Democracy: A Trilateral Commission Report on Governability*; 1975) authored by Michel Crozier, Samuel P Huntington and Joji Watanuki, examined the challenges faced by democratic governments in North America, Western Europe and Japan. The authors argued that democracies face issues like economic instability, declining public trust and the overloading of government, requiring a re-examination of basic premises to ensure the viability of democratic systems.

The report has high relevance in 2026 when the crisis of democracy is more or less the same everywhere and with a greater geographical spread.

As a psychological concept but undeniably with more frequent uses in pure politics, ‘The Power Paradox’ remains an enigma and that should be understood well as a functional democracy finally rests on votes and representation through popular will.

Hansen doesn’t miss the essence as she offers a final few words on her book’s last page: “By now, Erdogan’s pursuit of some perceived loss of Turkish dignity has curdled into bitterness and endless retribution. Someday he will lose the love he once inspired in people, and he too will go, leaving behind for his people a painful inheritance. He and his loyalists never made peace with the society or with the world. They never made peace with themselves.”

Hansen has penned a daring book. It is unputdownable and should be long-remembered as a major work on crisis-ridden Turkey and the crisis-ridden world at large. This is a book that deserves to be read and debated widely.

The reviewer is a policy professional, columnist and author

NEW READS.

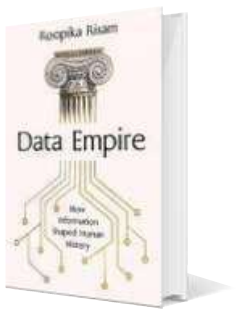


Title: The Indian Economy

Authors: Kaushik Basu, Sonalde Desai, Ashwini Deshpande, Nirvikar Singh

Publisher: Simon and Schuster India

This book delivers an the evidence-based analysis this pivotal moment demands

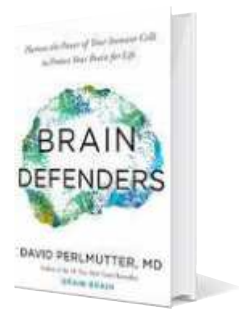


Title: Data Empire: How information shaped human history

Author: Roopika Risam

Publisher: PenguinRandom House

This book shows how data has always been the seed of power: a technology of control, shaping civilizations and upholding empires



Title: Brain Defenders: How to Protect Your Brain for Life

Author: David Perlmutter

Publisher: Hachette India

This book presents a lifestyle protocol that can help people become ‘architects of their cognitive destiny’

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

August 31, 2006

Defence: Govt to partner industry

The Defence Ministry on Wednesday announced a new procurement procedure that would allow the Indian industry to participate in defence re search, development and production. Under this new procedure, the Government will partner with Indian industry for the development of defence equipment and systems along with sharing of costs.

FLAG-VSNL dispute escalates

The dispute between FLAG Telecom, controlled by Mr Anil Ambani, and Videsh Sanchar Nigam Ltd, owned by Mr Ratan Tata, has escalated, with talks between the two on VSNL access charges hitting a wall. This has prompted FLAG to re-appeal to the ICC International Tribunal against VSNL, seeking that the latter come out with “reasonable and cost-based access charges.”

Ruia Group bids for entire Daewoo unit

The city-based Ruia Group, which took over Dunlop India recently, is the sole bidder for the entire unit of Daewoo Motor’s passenger car unit at Surajpur in Uttar Pradesh. This puts the Ruia group above other bidders such as the Tatas, Mahindras, and Ford who are keen on some assets of the auto-making unit.

Short take

Tukaram Mundhe and lessons on leadership

Aastha Tripathi

In a country where bureaucracy is often associated with files, procedures and institutional inertia, Tukaram Mundhe has acquired an unusual reputation: that of an officer who walks into a system and makes it move.

Maharashtra’s FDA Commissioner Tukaram Mundhe and his teams have conducted thousands of inspections of food businesses across Mumbai and Maharashtra, including prominent restaurants, large chains, street vendors and institutional kitchens, uncovering hygiene violations, expired products and licensing irregularities. But the more interesting story is not about raids,

restaurants or food safety. It is about leadership.

Mundhe’s 25 transfers over 21 years have not fundamentally altered the behavioural signature associated with him: a strong emphasis on rules, accountability and execution.

Modern leadership discourse often celebrates empathy, collaboration, psychological safety and participation. These are important. But leadership cannot be reduced to consensus.

Mundhe’s current food-safety campaign illustrates this distinction. A regulator is not appointed to maximise the satisfaction of those being regulated. The fundamental responsibility is to protect public interest.

That does not make every action

automatically right. Strong leadership must still operate within due process, proportionality and institutional checks.

One of the most important attributes of leadership is the capacity to act according to one’s institutional purpose even when doing so carries personal or professional costs.

Mundhe’s career demonstrates the potential cost of doing so. His frequent transfers have become almost synonymous with his public image. Yet perhaps the more important question is not why an officer gets transferred, but whether institutions can create environments in which principled disagreement does not become a career liability. There is, however, a danger in turning Mundhe into a superhero.

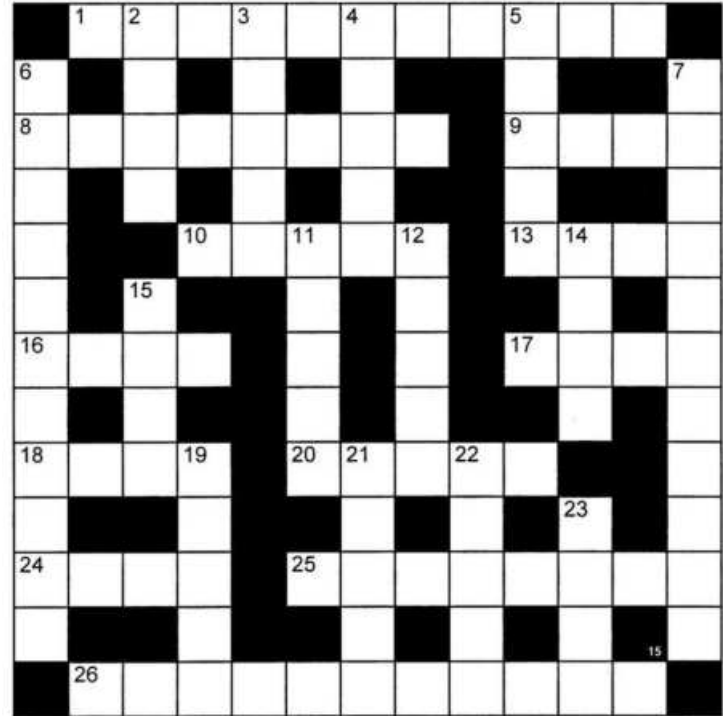
Institutions cannot depend on exceptional individuals forever. If food safety improves only because of one particular officer, the deeper governance problem remains unresolved.

Mundhe’s campaign offers Maharashtra an opportunity to improve. Inspections, licensing, laboratory capacity, enforcement protocols, transparency and citizen reporting must become institutional capabilities.

However, empathy without accountability can become indulgence. Authority without ethics can become coercion. But when purpose, integrity and accountability converge, leadership can become consequential.

The writer is Assistant Professor at TISS, Mumbai

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2725



EASY

ACROSS

- He lit gas lights in the street (11)
- Furniture-destroying pest (8)
- Happy, pleased (4)
- Glass bar triangular in section (5)
- A hefty volume (4)
- Back of shoe (4)
- Become limp, lose energy (4)
- In the midst of (4)
- Cry of snipe when flushed (5)
- Yorkshire dog (4)
- Right-hand man (8)
- Tape fastening kitchen garment (5-6)

DOWN

- Frenzied, wild (4)
- Physical or mental strength (5)
- Japanese boxes worn with traditional dress (5)
- Close-fitting (5)
- People in love with each other (11)
- Proclaiming publicly (11)
- Metal golf clubs (5)
- Mediterranean island (5)
- In short, an appreciation after death (4)
- Persian fairy (4)
- Cheerless, gloomy (5)
- Salad plant (5)
- A harness-racing horse (5)
- Portent, sign (4)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2724

- ACROSS** 1. Patience 4. Tsar 8. Roo 9. Judge 10. Can 11. Dingbat 12. Allow 13. Calling card 17. Beret 18. Bloater 20. Use 21. Oracy 22. Woe 23. Dish 24. Corporal
- DOWN** 1. Parody 2. Thorn 3. Cadet 5. Secular 6. Renown 7. Melancholy 9. Jubilation 14. Airless 15. Absurd 16. Ordeal 18. Bravo 19. Tower

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- The light was not as heavy as the fellow who got it going (11)
- It has a boring time, surrounded by furniture (8)
- Happy the eye one gives a pretty face! (4)
- Shaped piece of glass, sir, put back in the afternoon (5)
- My book indicates who to return it to if borrowed (4)
- One comes obediently to such a cad (4)
- Will you be old, and fade too? (4)
- Is surrounded by a thousand in assistance (4)
- Paces about after land for a country scene (5)
- The party keeps this wretched creature inside (4)
- Bird going to church to provide crew for a sidekick (8)
- One of two one is tied to under female domination (5-6)

DOWN

- Before midday it is all right to be in a frenzy (4)
- The might of the electricity supply (5)
- Japanese medicine-boxes made from 11 Down (5)
- Is tipsy, and that’s mean (5)
- They love taking card from a suit in confectionery (11)
- I’d invest rag such as this for giving one a puff (11)
- In which one was clapped for one’s bad performance (5)
- Half-animal, the Terriers from this island (5)
- Short appraisal that follows one’s departure (4)
- Beautiful fairy going around as a prefix (4)
- Dull the listener that follows the doctor (5)
- Loving gesture lacks a plant to put in salad (5)
- He will caper about but keep step with a runner (5)
- Sign a thousand in one version of it (4)

OUT OF STEP

A stylized illustration of a green battery with a white top and a white lightning bolt symbol, standing behind a row of white solar panels. The background is a light blue sky with green trees and a brown ground.

The lower FDRE tariffs suggest that developers are either absorbing a part of the cost increase through lower margins, or expecting to offset it through efficiencies and lower costs elsewhere in the project.

M Ramesh

But 'right of way' issues, mostly due to extortionate demands by



SUSTAINABLE ENDEAVOUR. By July this year, total renewable energy capacity in India stood at 240 GW BLOOMBERG

A recent paper produced by industry expert and RERTC Infra Director Bhupesh Trivedi estimates that annual solar additions may settle in the 30–40 GW range during 2027–30. Even allowing for the fact that module requirements exceed AC capacity additions, the

The irony is that while module manufacturing capacity threatens to outrun demand, domestic cell shortages are simultaneously raising costs. Rating agency ICRA has cautioned that the combined effect of domestic cell sourcing, rupee depreciation and higher commodity prices could raise the cost of utility-scale solar projects by 20–25 per cent in the near term, putting fur-

Year-wise capacity addition of battery energy storage system (BESS) projects

Year	In operation/commissioned		Under construction		Awarded project		Under tendering		Total capacity	
	MW	MWh	MW	MWh	MW	MWh	MW	MWh	MW	MWh
Upto March 2025	84.5	215.6							84.5	215.6
2025-26	193.35	574.6							193.35	574.6
2026-27	2,750	8,290	6,688	16,680.5	Nil	Nil	125.9	503	9,563.90	25,473.5
2027-28			11,858.44	32,923.82	3,912	14,456.2	3,691	15,989	19,461.44	63,369.02
2028-29			2,675	9,775	3,415	10,890	15,035.41	49,324.34	21,125.41	69,989.34
2029-30			Nil	Nil	Nil	Nil	1,200	4,800	1,200	4,800
Total	3,027.85	9,080.2	21,221.44	59,379.32	7,327	25,346.2	20,052.31	70,616.34	51,628.6	1,64,422.06

Note: Timeline for the commissioning of under-construction, awarded, and under-tendering BESS projects has been estimated with reference to the guidelines issued by the Ministry of Power for firm and despatchable renewable energy (FDRE), hybrid, round-the-clock, and standalone BESS projects.



Source: Ministry of Power

M Ramesh

India needs locally made

The US's cell manufactur-

"This dynamic situation creates a prime export opportunity," he said.

Bilateral deal under Article 6.2 of the Paris Agreement could fetch lucrative prices for transferable credits

M Ramesh

India has concluded bilateral arrangements with Japan and South Korea, while talks are on with Singapore, Switzerland and Sweden, according to Yashodhan Ramteke, CEO of EcoGuard Global, a Switzerland-headquartered climate-tech company building digitally traceable infrastructure for carbon markets. For Indian firms, Ramteke says Japan could offer an especially attractive opportunity.

FOURTEEN OPPORTUNITIES

India has identified 14 activities that can potentially generate internationally transferable credits under Article 6.2. These include renewable energy



The list also includes tidal and other ocean energy technologies, high-voltage direct current (HVDC) trans-

India has separately prescribed greenhouse gas emission reduction targets for obligated industrial entities. According to Ramteke, around 490

Unlike Japan, Singapore does not operate a conventional carbon credit trading market; it imposes a carbon tax. Companies liable for the tax can partially offset it using eligible international carbon credits.

A carbon credit generated by an eligible project may soon have a market beyond India's borders — and Japan, with a stated appetite for large volumes of internationally generated emission reductions, could become one of the most promising buyers.

OFFICE BUZZ.

Weighty matters

PepsiCo will stop covering weight-loss drugs on company health insurance, starting October, due to rising costs, according to Bloomberg, which cited an email the cola major sent to employees.

PepsiCo is the latest in a growing line of US-based companies curtailing coverage. An earlier Reuters report said several companies were planning to phase out coverage for weight-loss drugs in employee healthcare insurance plans for 2027, as GLP-1 usage rises. For HR leaders, and CFOs, a GLP-1 strategy has become an important conversation as these medications improve outcomes related to obesity, diabetes and heart health but, at the same time, they are driving up healthcare spends. Indian companies in general are not covering weight-loss drugs at the moment.

Intent to expand

Corporate occupiers in the Indian office market are entering a phase of conviction-led growth, says a new survey from CBRE South Asia, which notes that three in four intend to expand their portfolio over the next two years. The commercial real estate firm's annual study finds that about 30 per cent of respondents plan to grow their office portfolio in India by more than 30 per cent over the next two years. The survey was conducted between April and June 2026. Nearly half of those surveyed plan to expand their real estate footprint by coupling business growth with consolidation strategies. A quarter intend to renew existing leases over the next two years. The Indian office market has shown a strong performance in the last few years, with gross leasing at a record 24.6 million sq ft in Q2 2026, up 18 per cent sequentially and 14 per cent year-on-year.

Talent migration dynamics: Parochial vs practical?

PEOPLE @WORK
KAMAL KARANTH

Take me home, country roads' by John Denver is one of my favourite numbers and I loved playing it on loop while driving to my picturesque hometown, Udupi, 400 km from the noise and bustle of Bengaluru. The nostalgia of growing up there eventually pushed me to set up an office in that town. However, when some of my colleagues started telling me they wanted to be in Bengaluru for their next career journey, I asked myself what had I done. Despite Bengaluru's crumbling infrastructure and crawling traffic, the younger generation appeared keen to move to the megapolis.

WORKPLACE AND WORKER

Big cities around the world have continuously attracted the best talent from other cities and countries, thanks to attractive career opportunities. New York, San Francisco, Singapore, and London are sought-after cities to migrate for work. In India, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Gurugram, Pune, Chennai, and Mumbai are the six big cities when it comes to top white-collar jobs. In the last few years, however, other state capitals have tried to break the stranglehold of the 'Big 6' by enticing enterprises with a plethora of incentives. It's a welcome trend, as urban planning in the Big 6 hasn't kept pace with employment growth. But I am not sure whether free benefits are enough to attract MNCs, which look at several other factors too when deciding on a location. Talent density, Grade A real estate, and travel connectivity are the top three criteria for MNCs entering new cities. As for employees, the top preconditions for migrating to a new place are diverse career opportunities, and an easy commute to and from their home city. Most Indian states and tier 2 towns are still work in progress in these areas.

NEGATIVE CAMPAIGNS

Nine years ago, I was at a promotional event of a prominent State

Suresh P Iyengar

First they clashed over cement. Now, the corporate rivalry between the Aditya Birla Group and Adani Group is shifting to aluminium. Hindalco Industries, the flagship metals company of the Aditya Birla Group, plans to deploy around ₹50,000 crore in capacity expansion, upstream integration and downstream value-added products, in a bid to strengthen its market position ahead of the Adani Group's entry into the aluminium business.

Beyond producing more aluminium, Hindalco's bigger bet is on controlling a bigger chunk of the value chain and moving towards specialised products, since their earnings are less exposed to London Metal Exchange (LME) prices. This move is significant because Adani Enterprises has joined hands with Abu Dhabi-based natural resources investment platform International Resources Holding (IRH) to build a ₹1.08-lakh-crore integrated greenfield aluminium complex in Odisha.

The emerging contest isn't unlike the two groups' rivalry in cement, with UltraTech Cement, the Birla Group flagship, having to defend its leadership through organic expansion and acquisitions, including India Cements and Kesoram Industries. Its capacity has crossed 200 million tonnes per annum and is targeted to reach around 240 mtpa by FY28.

The Adani Group entered the cement segment in 2022 with the acquisition of Ambuja Cements and ACC from Holcim, and then Sanghi Industries, Penna Cement and Orient Cement. Its capacity is now around 109 mtpa, with a target of 140 mtpa by FY28. In the case of aluminium, scale, resource security, energy costs and vertical integration could determine competitive advantage.

BIG INVESTMENTS

The Adani-IRH project envisages a 4-mtpa alumina refinery near bauxite mines in Rayagada district, a 2-mtpa aluminium smelter, a 4,000-MW captive power plant and a 1-mtpa downstream manufacturing park in Sundargarh district.

Spread over 7,300 acres, the two phases of the project entail mega investments of around ₹66,000 crore and ₹44,000 crore, respectively.

Bauxite is expected from Odisha Mining Corporation's Sasubahumali

ALUMINIUM WAR

Birla vs Adani: Heavy metal face-off

INDUSTRIAL DUEL. After cement, the Birla-Adani rivalry shifts to aluminium as Hindalco mounts a ₹50,000-crore response to a massive greenfield challenge



TESTING METTLE. Hindalco Industries' Mahan Aluminium factory in Bargawan, Singrauli district, Madhya Pradesh

mines and Adani's Kutrumali and Bahalda mines. The ore will be moved through conveyor belts and rail to reduce logistics costs.

Adani Enterprises has indicated that clearances could take 12-18 months, and project development about three and a half years. Hindalco is ready with a response. "They are at the announcement stage, while we are actually expanding and constructing projects on the ground," said Satish Pai, Managing Director, Hindalco.

In January, Hindalco announced ₹21,000 crore investment to add 3.6 lakh tonnes a year of smelting capacity at its Aditya Aluminium complex in Sambalpur. Its current cumulative aluminium smelting capacity is 13 lakh tonnes a year. Overall, Hindalco plans to invest around ₹37,000 crore in Odisha across upstream and downstream aluminium operations.

"Our refinery project is about halfway through and scheduled for commissioning in December next year. Our smelter expansions are also coming online next year," Pai said.

THE INTEGRATED ADVANTAGE

Hindalco believes its ecosystem of mining, refining, smelting, downstream manufacturing and recycling capabilities is its biggest defence against any new entrant.

"We have been in this business for over 68 years and have an established

base and assets to build on," Pai said.

Hindalco has also sharpened its management structure. Kailash Pandey, formerly head of mining and the Sambalpur cluster, has been elevated as CEO of Aluminium Upstream, while Kopal Agrawal has been appointed CEO of Aluminium Downstream.

Hindalco's aluminium business is being built around two objectives: secure the upstream cost base and capture more value downstream.

Kumar Mangalam Birla, Chairman of Hindalco Industries, has pointed to the company's earlier investments of about ₹45,000 crore in Mahan Aluminium, Aditya Aluminium and Utkal Alumina as the foundation for its current expansion. "Today, Aditya, the fully integrated complex, combines upstream, downstream and recycling operations, giving a unique advantage across the value chain," Birla said.

Hindalco and its US-based subsidiary Novelis are together investing around \$10 billion in organic growth — a historic high for the company.

THE DOWNSTREAM BET

Hindalco's expansion is focused on engineered products that are high-margin and not linked to LME prices. Factors such as engineering capability, product specifications, quality, technology and long-term customer relationships can determine pricing and margins.

TABLE TALK

A new lease of life for Mitra's corporate career

Vinay Kamath

Suparna Mitra and I decide to meet at one of the many delectable dives that dot upscale Indiranagar in Bengaluru. She plumps for a place with a name appropriate for these times, Dongle Café. I'm early for our 6 pm meeting and choose a table for two in a narrow balcony outside the noisy air-conditioned area, where many work furiously on their laptops. A huge jackfruit tree frames the balcony; the chirp of birds and raucous caws of crows rent the air, muting the sounds of the street traffic below.

I order a green jasmine tea and a rosemary thyme cookie while I wait for the MD and CEO of TeamLease, one of the country's largest staffing companies. Mitra joined in February this year after a 24-year career in Titan Co, including five as CEO of the watches and wearables division, while the co-founders of TeamLease, Manish Sabharwal and Ashok Reddy, transitioned roles 25 years after the company started — Reddy to executive vice chairman and Sabharwal as a non-independent director.

Mitra soon arrives for our tete-a-tete. It's a bit of an odd time before dinner, so she prefers not to eat and asks for a blueberry juice with chia seeds. I ask about her transition from Titan onto a very different assignment. She explains, "It was a good moment because I was keen on learning something about a completely new category. Obviously, I've never worked in staffing or even in an HR services company — the way it runs, its rhythm, the type of clients — and this is B2B. I had always done B2C. So it's been a big learning for me."

She reels off mind-boggling figures. TeamLease has 3.5 lakh people on its rolls, of whom 2,500 work for the company and the rest for other companies. TL manages their payroll, compliance, PF, gratuity, and often the hiring itself. In FY25-26, TeamLease had revenues of ₹11,860 crore and handled over 4,000 clients.

Sipping her blueberry drink slowly, Mitra explains that in TeamLease there is something called general staffing — a large segment of the workforce, mainly entry-level sales or retail store staff across companies. "But we also have specialised staffing, which is really a lot of both IT as well as other specialised skills; it could be from finance to legal people. We do a lot of work with GCCs. It's really booming; there are 120-plus GCCs that we work with," she adds.

TeamLease, she says, has a very large operations team as the salaries of so many people need to go out every month. And at any point, TL is hiring about 20,000 people per month. "So everything from the offer letter to the associate to the final settlement and everything else in-between needs to be managed. We had our employee rewards a few weeks back, and one of those in the operations team that got rewarded was in charge of processing 5 lakh Form 16s. Of course, it is automated, but still needs a lot of manual checking," she explains.

A trend that is gaining ground is that both



ROLL CALL. Suparna Mitra, MD and CEO, TeamLease ILLUSTRATION: VIVISEWARAN V

employers and employees want flexibility. "So earlier, temp was a stopgap until you got a permanent job. But today, a lot of youngsters are thinking of multi-careers in multiple decades. And that level of flexibility allows many things — learning, multiple revenue streams, work-life balance. A lot of them also choose this for learning, because every time you take a new assignment you're learning something new. And for employers also this works, except for some very core functions," she adds.

As the conversation swivels to Mitra's early years, I order a Mexican grill chicken sandwich, which takes a while to arrive. Mitra's father was an engineer with Steel Authority of India, so she was born in the steel township of Bhilai. Her childhood was mostly spent in such steel towns and then five years in Delhi. Her parents moved to Kolkata when she was in class 11. "I was the youngest of three sisters and I was pampered, not in material terms — in the 1970s nobody had anything really — but in affection. Both my parents were progressive."

Post school Mitra attended Jadavpur University for a course in electrical engineering, but by the third year she was clear that was not what she wanted to do. IIM-Calcutta after that was transformative. "The courses in economics, sociology, psychology, behavioural sciences just blew my mind. It was a very impactful experience and, of course, all those friendships you make for life," she explains.

Picked up from campus by HUL, she was placed in Brooke Bond, where she worked a couple of years before joining Titan in its international division in 1994. But in four years she had quit and, after a short stint in a software company, she joined Arvind Brands as business head. In 2006 Titan called her back and she joined as marketing head for Titan watches.

the second half of 2026 are expected to strengthen Novelis' position in beverage packaging, automotive and speciality products.

As Bay Minette ramps up, Novelis is expected to support Hindalco's objective of achieving adjusted EBITDA of \$600 per tonne. The group has 19 plants in India and 29 overseas. Annual revenue is around \$31 billion.

This global downstream network gives Hindalco an advantage that a new primary aluminium producer will take time to replicate.

DEMAND WAVE

The Ministry of Mines estimates domestic aluminium consumption will rise from about 6.1 million tonnes in FY26 to around 28 million tonnes by FY47. The country also targets self-sufficiency in bauxite and alumina by 2035. Copper, central to electrification, is expected to see similarly sharp growth, with domestic refined copper consumption projected to rise from around 0.9 million tonnes in FY26 to 3.6 million tonnes by FY47.

Hindalco can position itself not merely as a commodity producer but also supplier of materials and components for the next phase of industrialisation. The company is already working with customers on lighter, safer and more efficient components, deploying process scientists, alloy specialists, modelling experts and design engineers on the job.

POWER REMAINS CRITICAL

Hindalco is betting on renewable power to improve its long-term cost position while reducing the carbon intensity of production. It is currently the only aluminium producer in India with round-the-clock renewable power. The company has secured 400 MW of renewable energy, supported by a gross captive renewable pipeline of more than 1.3 GW and energy storage capacity exceeding 1 GWh.

Since aluminium smelting is energy-intensive, a combination of captive power, renewable energy, resource security and integrated logistics can determine where a producer sits on the global cost curve.

This is where the contest with Adani could become interesting. Adani brings expertise in infrastructure, ports, power, logistics and large-scale project execution — suited to build an integrated aluminium chain around Odisha's mineral resources.

Hindalco's objective is clear: produce competitive primary metal, but also capture more value from every tonne before it reaches the customer.

DATA BANK.

Fraudsters match steps with fintech innovations

India's fraud landscape has metamorphised alongside the growth of digital financial services and fintech innovation, according to a report by Experian Credit Information Company of India.

The report, 'The new frontier: Emerging trends in fraud prevention', noted that the expansion of digital lending platforms, rising smartphone usage, and faster onboarding processes have improved financial inclusion but also created new avenues for fraud.

In the lending ecosystem, fraud is becoming more sophisticated and multi-dimensional, including identity theft, synthetic identities, mule accounts, and application fraud, often enabled by gaps in digital KYC and onboarding processes, the report found.

According to a recent annual report by the Reserve Bank of India, there is a surge in the value of anomalies in applications, even as the number of anomalies has declined across financial institutions during the last three years.

The amount involved in suspected applications has grown four times in the latest period (from ₹12,230 crore in FY24 to ₹48,021 crore in FY26), while the volume of suspected applications has declined significantly. The average ticket size of suspected applications has increased sharply from ₹34 lakh to ₹475 lakh during the same period.

Account takeover has emerged as the most widespread threat, with 77 per cent of respondents reporting an increase, indicating growing vulnerability in digital access and authentication layers. Money muling and identity theft are close behind (71 per cent each), highlighting the rise of organised, network-driven fraud.

Synthetic business fraud and first-party fraud show the highest "significant increase" (39 per cent), suggesting a shift toward more deliberate, high-impact fraud schemes.

The findings highlight that organisations face a broad spectrum of fraud threats, with several types proving particularly difficult to detect and prevent. Notably, a large number of respondents classify these threats as "very challenging".

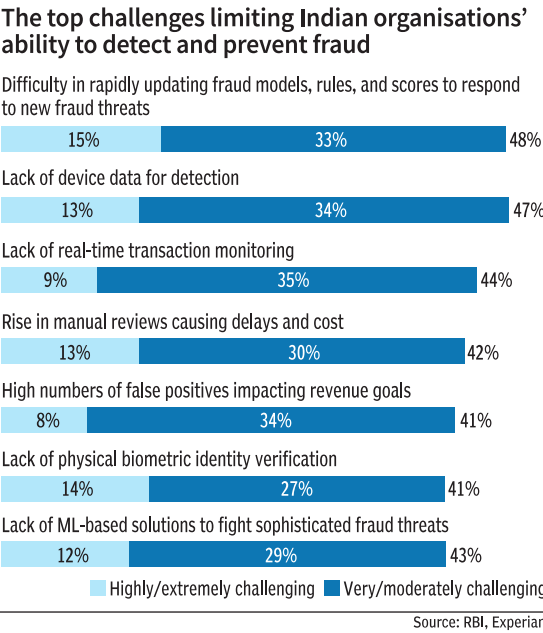
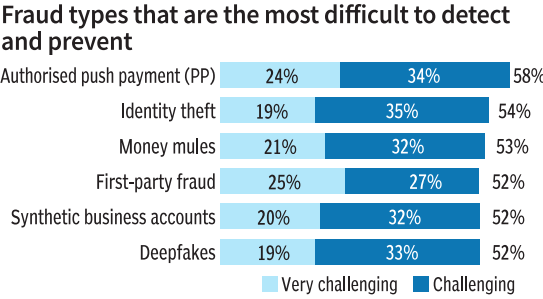
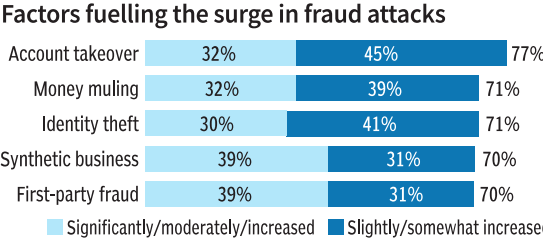
Authorised push payment (APP) fraud is the most challenging threat, with 58 per cent of organisations finding it difficult to manage.

Identity theft and money mule activity remain persistent challenges (54 per cent and 53 per cent).

A broad range of fraud types — including first-party fraud, synthetic identities, and deepfakes (about 52 per cent) — are consistently challenging, indicating that fraud risk is diversifying rather than concentrated in a single category.

Manish Jain, Chairman, Experian Credit Information Company of India, observed that fraud prevention is undergoing a fundamental shift — from static, rules-based controls to adaptive, data-driven, and network-aware strategies. Organisations that embrace this evolution will be better positioned to mitigate rising exposure, strengthen onboarding controls, and stay ahead of increasingly sophisticated fraud and anomaly risks.

Number of anomalies in applications and corresponding amounts across lenders						
Lending institutions	2023-24		2024-25		2025-26	
	Anomalies in applications	Amount involved	Anomalies in applications	Amount involved	Anomalies in applications	Amount involved
Public sector banks	7,460	₹9,254	6,935	₹25,667	5,418	₹35,709
Private sector banks	24,207	₹2,722	14,233	₹10,088	3,956	₹11,399
Foreign banks	2,899	₹154	1,448	₹181	210	₹290
Other financial institutions	1,494	₹100	1,337	₹78	514	₹125



● LIC@70

Older, savvier, and more ambitious

INCLUSIVE COVER. Public sector life insurer believes age is on its side as it aims to reach newer places and age groups

K Ram Kumar
Mahesh Ravidas Nayak

Remaining India's No. 1 life insurer 70 years since inception and 26 years after the insurance sector was opened to private and foreign players is a remarkable achievement in itself, says R Doraiswamy, CEO and MD, Life Insurance Corporation of India.

In a freewheeling interaction with *businessline*, the LIC Chief emphasises that he wants to transform the corporation into a digitally strong entity, providing financial solutions — spanning protection, annuities, ULIPs and savings — that meet current needs.

To deepen its presence in the hinterland, India's sole public sector life insurer, which at last count had assets under management of about ₹59.39 lakh crore, has initiated efforts to have its representation at the panchayat (village self-government institutions) level.

Edited excerpts:

What are LIC's most important achievements since coming into being on September 1, 1956?

Standing tall as the No. 1 life insurer in the country after 70 years is, in itself, a great achievement. But the most important achievement has been the enduring trust that LIC has built among Indians.

Second, LIC has used that trust to contribute to nation-building and provide financial protection to millions of Indian households. It has transformed life insurance from what was largely considered "an instrument for the elite" into a household financial protection instrument.

Third is the unrivalled distribution network that LIC has built. Even after the opening up of the insurance sector, we have continued to build considerable distribution strength and bandwidth.

Another important achievement has been the development of a robust technology infrastructure, which provides the backbone for handling such large volumes of business.

How are you preparing for the challenges ahead?

We are a legacy organisation built on the trust of Indians. The challenge is to convert that legacy trust into an organisation that is nimble-footed, has a digital-first approach and provides solutions relevant to all generations and changing times.

There are many challenges involved, but we will continuously move towards remaining relevant and maintaining our strength.

How are you addressing these needs?

We are designing products accordingly. First, we are looking at greater flexibility in terms of premium contributions and payments. Second, the products need to meet long-term requirements by providing protection, lifelong income and benefits. Third, customers also expect an appropriate return from such instruments.

We also need to enable customers to deal with products in a do-it-yourself mode, which appeals to the current generation.

We are looking at meeting



SOUND POLICY. R Doraiswamy, CEO and MD, LIC of India

How would you appeal to Gen Z and Gen Alpha, for whom the traditional concept of institutional trust may not have the same significance it did for previous generations?

That is precisely why I spoke about transforming into a technology-driven organisation. The needs of the current generation are different from those of previous generations. There has been an increase in disposable income but, at the same time, there are significant uncertainties, including in the employment market.

The benefits of the traditional joint family system and the security it provided are also diminishing. Individuals are increasingly dependent on themselves for financial security. Life expectancy has also increased. People, therefore, need to plan for a longer period of survival than previous generations may have anticipated. We are transforming LIC into an organisation capable of meeting these emerging needs.

How are you addressing these needs?

We are designing products accordingly. First, we are looking at greater flexibility in terms of premium contributions and payments. Second, the products need to meet long-term requirements by providing protection, lifelong income and benefits. Third, customers also expect an appropriate return from such instruments.

We also need to enable customers to deal with products in a do-it-yourself mode, which appeals to the current generation.

We are looking at meeting

every customer requirement throughout the policy lifecycle through digital modes.

Where do you see the organisation by 2030?

We are conscious that as the market expands, with more players entering, market share will not remain static.

Our objective is to have a sustainable growth model while remaining the unquestioned market leader and the preferred long-term solution provider for the nation, including when we reach our 100th year. We need to continue growing at a rate that is at least slightly higher than the overall industry growth.

Life insurance penetration remains low in India. How can it be increased?

Penetration is measured as total insurance premium as a proportion of GDP. The fact that penetration has not increased sufficiently indicates that insurance premium growth has not kept pace with GDP growth.

The objective should be to bring more people under life insurance coverage. But having an insurance policy does not necessarily mean that a person has adequate insurance. The value of the policy relative to the customer's income and liabilities also needs to be examined. This is essentially the protection gap.

We need to focus on both aspects: bringing people who are outside the insurance system into the fold, and increasing the level of cover for those who already have insurance. This requires greater accessibility, affordability and products that meet customer needs.

What is the main hurdle in increasing insurance penetration?

One important factor is the trust deficit among customers, particularly in certain forms of insurance such as health and protection. When claim settlement experiences are not satisfactory, it creates a trust deficit. This needs to be addressed. More importantly, there needs to be greater adoption of insurance. We believe insurance should be treated as an integral part of financial management and wealth creation, and should ideally be incorporated into educational curriculum.

A strong insurance awareness campaign is required to significantly increase adoption of life insurance.

What steps are you taking to achieve the 'Insurance for all by 2047' goal?

One of the primary objectives for which LIC was established was to take the message of life insurance to every corner of the country. Geographical reach has, therefore, been an important focus. LIC currently has a physical presence in the form of an office in around 92 per cent of districts.

In other areas, we have representation through LIC agents, their offices, and empowered agents authorised to collect premiums and provide limited services.

The next step is to ensure representation at the panchayat level. We have initiated efforts to have LIC representation in every village panchayat in the country.

We also need to reach more people through our extensive physical network, as well as digital channels, thereby improving accessibility to insurance.

There are over 2.5 lakh panchayats. How will LIC reach all of them?

It will be a multiple-model approach. LIC has about 14.45 lakh agents, and we are looking at having an agent in every panchayat. We are identifying panchayats that don't have an LIC agent and visiting them to pick suitable people as insurance distributors. We have also launched (in December 2024) the women-centric Bima Sakhi — Women Career Agents (Stipendiary) Scheme — which has been a major success. We currently have around 2.8 lakh Bima Sakhis.

What proportion of India's panchayats currently have an LIC presence?

We have currently reached around 59 per cent of the panchayats, and are continuing to expand. We are trying to reach 100 per cent as quickly as possible.

sible. It is a massive exercise because, in some places, finding the right person is not easy. We expect to achieve this within the next couple of years.

LIC is now a listed company. How do you balance its traditional role in nation-building and serving policyholders with the expectations of shareholders for profitability?

There is indeed a thin line that separates these objectives. LIC has always been known for taking care of the interests of policyholders and working in the national interest.

Even when LIC was listed (in May 2022), the shareholders who came in were aware that this is an organisation built around the responsibility of providing insurance to the Indian public and mobilising people's savings for nation-building activities. They understand the objectives of the corporation and the principles on which it functions.

Having said that, after the listing, we have had to take into account a new set of stakeholders in the form of shareholders other than the government. We have, therefore, tried to balance both interests. We continue to focus on providing insurance cover and mobilising public savings while simultaneously improving the efficiency and performance of the corporation. The objective is to do justice to both policyholders and shareholders.

What is the status of LIC's proposed entry into health insurance?

There were discussions in the market that LIC could enter health insurance as a player, particularly when the government was considering amendments to the insurance legislation, including the possibility of composite licences.

We were looking at entering the health insurance sector as a strategic investor by taking a stake in an existing standalone health insurance company. But we have not reached a stage where we could finalise or identify a particular company for investment.

In the meantime, the new legislation, the Sabka Bima Sakhi Raksha Act, has been introduced and passed, but the provision for a composite licence has not been included. Therefore, currently there is no urgency to gain exposure to health insurance or general insurance.

We are keeping our options open. If a good opportunity presents itself, we will evaluate it to see if we can translate it into an investment. These decisions have to be based on the opportunities available.

A growth story written by global Indians

Why a rising number of non-resident Indians are eyeing their home country as a long-term investment destination



SANJAY AGARWAL

India's next growth chapter will be driven not just by domestic demand, manufacturing and digitalisation. It will also be shaped by one of the country's most influential and underutilised assets: its global diaspora.

Beyond remittances and emotional ties, overseas Indians — currently numbering 35-plus million — are turning into long-term participants in their native land's growth story.

India remains the world's largest recipient of remittances — \$143.6 billion in FY26. These inflows have supported millions of households, strengthened the country's external sector, and created enduring links with its diaspora.

However, the coming decade may mark a more significant transition — from remittances to long-term growth capital.

Increasingly, non-resident Indians (NRIs) are looking at India not only as home but also one of the world's most compelling long-term investment destinations. This reflects a growing confidence in the country's economic fundamentals and institutional ma-

turity. It paves the way for global Indian capital to become a meaningful participant in the nation's development journey.

INVESTMENT CASE

Although the world's sixth-largest economy in dollar terms, India remains the fastest-growing major economy, supported by robust domestic demand, an expanding manufacturing base, rapid infrastructure development and a vibrant digital economy.

Macroeconomic fundamentals have also strengthened. Foreign exchange reserves remain strong at over \$700 billion, providing resilience against external shocks. Inflation remains well managed, fiscal consolidation continues, and the banking system is stronger, cleaner and better capitalised than it was a decade ago.

Equally important has been the consistency of reform. GST, the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, production-linked incentive schemes, digital public infrastructure and sustained investment in connectivity have helped build a more formal, productive and competitive economy.

Additionally, global supply chains are diversifying and manufacturing investment is expanding. Technology-led businesses are scaling at speed. Infrastructure is improving. In-



DIASPORA LOVE. Staying invested back home PFI

dia's young demographic provides a long runway for expansion. Many overseas Indians are showing a growing interest in the capital markets, startups, alternative assets, infrastructure and wealth management solutions on offer in the country of their origin.

MATURE MARKETS

Given the growing interest from overseas Indians, the country must continue simplifying their investment journey. Perceptions around regulatory complexity, taxation, documentation requirements and cross-border investment processes remain barriers. Continued efforts towards transparency, ease of investing and digital enablement can further unlock the immense potential of global Indian capital.

The country's financial ecosystem has, meanwhile, ma-

tured significantly. Equity market capitalisation reached \$5.18 trillion in July this year, retaining its position among the largest equity markets globally. Mutual fund assets under management expanded to ₹85.76 lakh crore, with monthly SIP contributions reaching a record ₹31,961 crore during the month.

Historically, investments by overseas Indians were concentrated in real estate, gold or bank deposits. Today, the opportunity spans equities, debt markets, REITs, infrastructure investment trusts, alternative investment funds, manufacturing, renewable energy, and the growing innovation ecosystem.

DIGITAL ACCESS

Institutions such as the RBI, SEBI and IPSCA have strengthened governance standards, transparency and market integrity, while the development of GIFT IFSC is creating a globally competitive financial platform within India.

Simplified digital onboarding, electronic KYC and progressive reforms have made investing in India far more seamless for global investors.

Digital public infrastructure, including Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker and the Account Aggregator framework, has transformed access and financial participation. UPI alone pro-

cessed more than 23.66 billion transactions in July. For overseas Indians, digital infrastructure is reducing distance not just geographically but also economically.

Tier II and III cities are emerging as centres of entrepreneurship, consumption, manufacturing and innovation, enabled by improved infrastructure, expanding digital access and deeper financial inclusion.

The next investment opportunity in India increasingly lies in the aspirations of Bharat.

For long-term capital, this creates a deeper, more diversified and inclusive opportunity landscape.

The Indian diaspora today includes global CEOs, entrepreneurs, professionals, technologists and investors.

Their participation can take many forms: investments in capital markets, enterprise creation, infrastructure financing, startups, manufacturing, sustainability and innovation. Their capital, networks, expertise and global experience can accelerate India's growth ambitions across sectors.

Such capital does more than generate returns. It creates jobs, builds capacity, strengthens enterprises and contributes to national development.

The writer is the founder, MD and CEO of AU Small Finance Bank

QUICKLY.

SpaceX launches NASA's \$4.3 b space telescope



NASA's launched Roman, a \$4.3 billion telescope to space on Sunday, marking the beginning of a 5-10-year mission to observe the universe's most exotic phenomena. The launch puts the spacecraft on course to reach its final destination, an orbit roughly 1 million miles from Earth, where the spacecraft will begin observations as early as December. Roman is designed specifically to hunt for some of the most perplexing and mysterious forces in the universe. Notably, it'll be studying dark matter and dark energy. Roman will attempt to catalogue how dark matter and dark energy are shaping distant stars and galaxies. The first images from the Roman telescope are expected to arrive in 2027. **BLOOMBERG**

India emerges as key petrol supplier to Russia

New Delhi: India has emerged as a key supplier of petrol to Russia amid a surge in Russian fuel imports triggered by Ukrainian drone attacks on refineries, ship tracking data showed. Russia's seaborne gasoline imports surged to a record 125,000 barrels per day in August, according to energy analytics firm Vortexa. Indian refiners supplied as much as 1 million barrels in the last two months, trade sources said. The supplies essentially came from Vadinar refinery in Gujarat, operated by Nayara Energy, which is half owned by Russia's Rosneft. It's likely that fuel exported to Russia may have been made from Russian crude. **PTI**

Subhash Chandra revises total due to lenders to ₹4,262 crore

COUNTERCLAIM. The media baron said HDFC's claims had no 'valid personal guarantee'

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Zee Group Founder Subhash Chandra on Sunday detailed the outstanding balances owed to lenders in his personal insolvency matter, stating that the HDFC Group has made claims without a valid personal guarantee. Chandra's statement came in response to social media posts over the week-end carrying hashtags such as #PaiseVapasKaro (translation: return the money). Arguing that the campaign is based on "a wrong perception and understanding" of the matter, he outlined the total claims made by lenders who have objected the repayment plan.



Subhash Chandra

The NCLT had allowed Chandra to repay an amount of ₹6.5 crore against the admitted claims of over ₹22,000 crore, which he described as value of the total personal guarantees. With regards to the HDFC Group, Chandra's statement referred to four out of the five accounts of the bank and cited an outstanding balance of ₹775 crore. Against this

claim, the statement included a remark that said "claims without valid personal guarantee". However, it does not provide details of the fifth account. He also mentions outstanding dues for multiple accounts of LIC Housing Finance at ₹1,322 crore stating that he "offered to settle. Part security available." HDFC is one of the foremost lenders to consider an appeal before the NCLAT against the NCLT order that allowed Chandra to pay the revised amount. LIC Housing Finance followed soon after, along with Canara Bank and Union Bank whose outstanding balances are ₹348 crore and ₹164 crore. According to Chandra's latest statement, the total outstanding dues to lenders

amount to ₹4,262 crore from the earlier stated ₹3,992 crore. "Amounts differ... because some accounts were not taken as they neither voted for or against," said Chandra's office. **RECONCILIATION** The media baron stated he has discussed the matter with borrowers and received an assurance to settle the ₹4,262 crore after reconciliation with lenders. "Subhash Chandra hopes that the lenders will also engage with the borrowers, reconcile the outstanding accounts and recover their dues. He also hopes that those who supported #PaiseVapasKaro, as well as others commenting on social media will be satisfied with this," the statement said.

Atlassian bets big on India as AI changes software development

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Atlassian is positioning its India development centre as a strategic R&D hub as the company expands its use of AI agents and builds products around its Teamwork Graph technology, said Vikram Rao, CTO, Enterprise and Chief Trust Officer at Atlassian. The India site has grown to more than 2,700 employees, with a large portion working across engineering, product and design, while the company is also expanding its sales workforce in the country, Rao said. In September 2025, Atlassian announced a new R&D Centre in Bengaluru. Spanning over 2 lakh square feet, the new space is four times the size of the company's previous Bengaluru office. The teams based in the city



Vikram Rao, Chief Trust Officer, Atlassian

are responsible for several of Atlassian's core product and technology areas, including its Service Collection, machine-learning platform and search capabilities. "We have a core product line operating out of here called Service Collection, which is a billion-dollar-plus revenue-generating vertical. It operates primarily in IT-service management and caters to DevOps as well as IT Ops, fully running from

India," said Rao. "India has a strategic side that drives revenue for us." Rao said the rapid improvement in AI-assisted software development is lowering the barrier to creating software, but shifting the challenge towards deciding what should be built. "The problem has shifted from how can you create software to creating a lot of software quickly. Therefore, what to create becomes important."

HIRING PLANS Atlassian plans to continue expanding its India operations, with hiring across engineering and sales. Rao said the company has also had success hiring directly from Indian universities, adding that fresh graduates bring an advantage as AI-native workers. "I've doubled down on wanting to bring in students from university," Rao said.

Nepal floods leave thousands in temporary shelters with a new ordeal

Press Trust of India
Nuwakot (Nepal)

For thousands of people who escaped Nepal's devastating floods, the emergency has not ended. They are now living in temporary shelters, often without medicines and basic necessities they had before the waters swept through their communities. According to a government update reported by local media, three relief camps have been established in Rasuwa and 15 in Nuwakot, while temporary accommodation has been arranged in schools and public and community buildings for about 3,500 displaced people. The death toll crossed 750



LEND A HAND. A man gives support to an elderly near an area covered in mud and debris in the aftermath of flash floods in Nepal's Nuwakot. Over 2,500 people are still said to be missing **PTI**

on Sunday, while more than 2,500 people were still missing. Families crowded hospitals searching for missing relatives as rescuers continued digging through mud and debris amid intermittent rainfall and renewed concerns over rising river levels. Nepal Police said about 1,000 displaced people were staying in nine holding centres in Nuwakot on Sat-

urday, according to *The Kathmandu Post*. Separately, the newspaper reported that about 1,000 people were staying at three displacement camps around Trishuli Hospital. The camps are sheltering people with a range of needs, including pregnant women, new mothers and those requiring medical care, the report said. But the shelters are facing shortages of clean drinking water and sanitation.

NO IDEA OF WHAT NEXT A monastery on the outskirts of Kathmandu is providing temporary shelter to around 500 people displaced by the flash floods that devastated Rasuwa district near the Nepal-Tibet border on Wednesday. But the shelter is

only a temporary arrangement and cannot provide accommodation and other support to the displaced people in the long term, the monas-

tery management committee said. Many of those staying there have no idea where they will go next, as their homes are buried.

The scale of the relief effort is likely to evolve as rescue teams reach cut-off areas and people move between shelters.

Over 500 remain unaccounted for at hydropower projects

Press Trust of India
Kathmandu

As many as 537 workers and employees remained unaccounted for at nine hydropower projects in flood-hit Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts, with rescue teams intensifying efforts to reach people believed to be trapped inside tunnels. Rescue operations have been hampered by mud and debris

blocking tunnel entrances, damaged infrastructure, difficult terrain and adverse weather, prompting Nepal to seek specialised assistance from India, China and other countries. According to the Independent Power Producers' Association in Nepal, 898 workers and employees at nine hydropower projects in the two districts were initially reported out of contact following the August 26 floods. Of them, 361 have been rescued, leaving 537

still unaccounted for, according to local media reports. International assistance has, meanwhile, been deployed to support Nepal's tunnel rescue efforts. An 11-member Indian team comprising doctors, paramedics and tunnel engineers carried out on-site reconnaissance of tunnels on Saturday, the Indian Embassy in Kathmandu said. The team had arrived in Kathmandu on Friday and reached Trishuli in Nuwakot district on Saturday.

AI is like a marathon, but you have to run it like a sprint: Gnani.ai CEO

bl.interview

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

One of the oldest artificial intelligence (AI) firms of the country, Gnani.ai has recently launched Gnani Artha, an end-to-end sovereign AI stack for Indian enterprises and public institutions, built on two key components — Gnani Evon v3.3, a 30-billion-parameter open-weights model trained natively across 11 Indian languages — and Gnani Plexus, the company's agentic AI platform. Gnani Artha is backed by the government's India AI Mission.

The company that has the largest deployments of voice AI in the world, in terms of volumes, is now looking at family of models with such models. In an interview with *businessline*, Ganesh Gopalan, Co-founder and Chief Executive Officer, Gnani.ai, said as AI is still in the nascent phase in India there is a lot of scope for everyone, but there is no time to look sideways at competition and one should focus on doing things they are best at.

Edited excerpts:

What is the USP of Gnani Artha?

Gnani Artha is really our sovereign platform, which will host a bunch of models. It is a 30-billion parameter model. In the future, there will be a whole family of models. We are planning to launch 100-plus billion parameter models.

First is 70-billion parameter, then 100-plus billion parameter and each model has its own uses. The reason why we have launched this 30 billion parameter model will be very different from the reasons why we will launch a 100-billion parameter model. We wanted to do this model for Indic language capability, and there's a benchmark that we have



There has to be some regulation for sure. But it has to be done in a way that doesn't stifle the industry

GANESH GOPALAN
Co-founder and CEO

called MILU. The tokens consumed here for languages like Gujarati, Malayalam, which is always tougher points for global models, which they struggle, consume at least 40 per cent less tokens than them.

We are offering it as a sovereign piece and anybody can take it and launch it within their own servers with complete security.

How difficult or challenging is to cover multiple languages and dialects in your models? That's a specific challenge and if you see global languages, global models, they don't work for this. But, we also have speech-text models that work with almost every language of India and we call it Prisma. That's the most accurate model in the industry today, and there again, we are adding more languages.

Like you said, the biggest challenges are some languages which don't have a written text. But we started our company as a speech to text one back in 2017 and we built India's first speech to text models. And, now we are looking at launching more languages. We are collecting data everyday for that. We have the largest dedicated data set in the world for Indian languages.

As competition is rising, especially with a lot of startups and companies from foreign lands too in this space, and some even launching models for free, how do you plan to beat them?

I think firstly, this is not the time to look sideways at competition. We are in a business that is expanding at an incredible pace and we are actually saying no to a lot of business because we are unable to expand our sales and support teams at the pace that customers are willing to work with us.

And, there will be opportunities for multiple people. AI is like a marathon, but it's a marathon that you have to run like a sprint, and in a sprint the moment you start looking sideways, you are gone. So, there is a place for everybody, and you should focus on the battles that you are fighting.

For instance, a lot of people think that it is one metric that defines a model. But, it is not. It's like Onam *Sadhya*. You have so many elements in it, each tastes different, and each person would have a liking for a different dish. So that's what the models are for, and a competitor may be focused on different problems than us. I think there is just enough business and market because we are in day zero of AI and we have a lot more to go.

On the policies side, the government is planning for AI regulation now. Do you support the idea and what inputs would you like to give?

It's a very tricky thing...do you want to go like the Europe way or the US way. I think India will go somewhere in between. Probably more towards the US way. We should definitely also be very careful of deepfakes. I feel there has to be some regulation for sure. But it has to be done in a way that doesn't stifle the industry.

GE expanded inspections after 2023 AI incident, DGCA tells CIC

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The 2023 in-flight shutdown of an engine on an Air India Boeing 787-8 aircraft prompted manufacturer GE Aerospace to expand bore-scope inspection requirements for affected engines, the DGCA told the Central Information Commission.

The disclosure came in an RTI case concerning action taken by the aviation regulator after the final report on the Mumbai incident of August 2023. The applicant had sought to know if action was taken against Air India.

The DGCA told the commission that after the acceptance of the final investigation report, it was forwarded to the Directorate of Airworthiness for necessary action.

Bahwan CyberTek bullish on AI-driven products and public sector tech spending

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Despite continuing geopolitical uncertainty, technology spending by governments and businesses across West Asia remains robust, and continues to be robust growth opportunities for IT-solutions provider Bahwan CyberTek, its new MD and CEO Amrinder Singh said.

Roughly a third of the company's business comes from the US, West Asia, and India and the Far East each. Singh, who has spent almost three decades in the IT sector before joining BCT two months ago, expects the West Asian market to continue growing. "Oman and the UAE are core markets for us. We do a lot of work for them in public



Amrinder Singh, MD and CEO, Bahwan CyberTek

sector, energy, and banking and financial sectors," said Singh. "One of our clients in Oman is one of the largest petroleum developmental organisations. We run an end-to-end IT managed services for them."

The company believes its heritage of being an Indian IT company, backed by the prominent family from

Oman, the Suhail Bahwan Group, also gives it an advantage.

THE ADVANTAGE The 27-year-old firm has an annual run rate of about \$250 million and the new CEO believes its relatively smaller employee base of 5,500 gives it greater flexibility than large IT-services companies to adopt AI, re-train employees and respond quickly to changing customer requirements. Almost everybody in the technology function, in the delivery function is AI trained, said Singh. The company is looking to grow at 10-15 per cent over the next two to three years.

The Chennai-based company also has around a dozen proprietary products, many of them built around IoT

capabilities. "We are now infusing AI into these products to improve their value to customers," Singh said. Given the recent oil market situation, BCT has seen two new orders from Indian clients and is also in discussions with oil marketing companies in three African countries, with pilots underway.

LOCALISATION EDGE Singh noted that a changing geopolitical environment is accelerating demand for localised technology services and delivery teams. BCT has already built local delivery capabilities in markets such as Oman, Taiwan and Brunei. The company is also planning to use JVs and special purpose vehicles to expand in its existing international markets.

How TVS Motor's dealer-training programme lifted sales by 300%

The approach tackles a problem familiar to auto dealerships: information overload on both sides of the counter

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Sell more by saying less, and use the bike as a memory map. That is the counter-intuitive approach behind a sales programme designed for TVS Motor's dealer network that reached about 650 participants across Uttar Pradesh, Haryana and Rajasthan.

Catalyst Training Services, the Bengaluru-based consultancy that designed and delivered the programme, has said 15 dealerships in Rajasthan subsequently reported 5-300 per cent increase in sales over their respective previous monthly averages.

Instead of loading salespeople with every feature in a brochure, Catalyst identified a limited number of competitive differentiat-

ors and arranged them around the physical geography of the motorcycle. As the salesperson moved around the bike, the motorcycle itself became a memory map — cueing what needed to be demonstrated next and turning the sales pitch into a set of simple, observable and repeatable behaviours.

THE VITAL FEW

The approach tackles a problem increasingly familiar to auto dealerships: information overload on both sides of the counter.

Customers often arrive after consuming product videos, reviews, comparisons and social-media content. Salespeople face the other side of the same problem, juggling specifications, competitive information, sales processes, SOPs, CRM practices and customer-ex-



SIMPLE LESSON. For auto dealerships, selling more vehicles to informed customers may increasingly mean giving salespeople less to remember

perience requirements. "The modern sales problem is no longer an information deficit. It is an information-overload problem, on both sides of the counter," said Madhusudhan P, founder of Catalyst Training Services.

Catalyst's research in the motorcycle segment identified what it calls a "product-value visibility disadvant-

age". The products did not necessarily lack customer-relevant advantages. Instead, buyers would fail to see those differences unless salespeople deliberately mentioned, demonstrated and compared them.

Catalyst said randomly selected participants typically scored below 25 per cent in demonstration proficiency before the inter-

vention. After 30-40 minutes of observing, practising and repeating the methodology, the same participants typically crossed 80 per cent.

TRAINING TO SELLING "Organisations have invested heavily in product knowledge, processes, SOPs and training, leaving the salesperson with hundreds of things to remember and do," Madhusudhan said. "The challenge is identifying the vital few among the important many."

For dealerships facing buyers who know the specifications before entering the showroom, the lesson is simple: selling more may increasingly mean giving salespeople less to remember — and making what matters easier for customers to see.